

MODULE 4

Memory Management and Performance

Write efficient, reliable applications by managing memory wisely and optimizing performance.







MEMORY MANAGEMENT AND PERFORMANCE

Efficient memory management by the JVM ensures high performance, stability and scalability of Java applications.

MEMORY ALLOCATION



Object Creation

Objects are created in the Heap memory using new keyword.



Object Dereference

Objects with no references become eligible for Garbage Collection.

JVM MEMORY AREAS

HEAP (Shared)

Young Generation

Eden Space

Survivor Spaces (S0, S1)

Old Generation (Tenured)

NON-HEAP (Shared)

Metaspace
Class metadata

Code Cache
Compiled code

Thread Stacks
Each thread has its stack

PC Registers
Program counter for threads

Native Method Stack
Native method execution

OBJECT FLOW

New Object

Young Generation (Eden)

Survivor Spaces (S0 / S1)

Old Generation (Tenured)

PERFORMANCE FACTORS



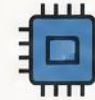
Garbage Collection

Efficient GC minimizes pause time and improves application responsiveness.



Memory Usage

Optimal memory usage reduces latency and improves throughput.



CPU Utilization

Balanced CPU usage ensures better execution and faster processing.



Tuning JVM

Proper JVM parameters (Xms, Xmx, GC type) boost performance.



Avoid Memory Leaks

Release unused objects and resources to maintain performance.

GARBAGE COLLECTION CYCLE



1. Mark

Identify live objects that are still reachable.



2. Sweep

Remove unreachable objects and free the memory.



3. Compact

Compact memory by eliminating fragmentation.



4. Repeat

Cycle repeats to maintain optimal memory.

BEST PRACTICES

- Use appropriate data structures
- Avoid memory leaks and unnecessary object creation
- Tune JVM heap size and GC options
- Monitor memory and GC using tools (jvisualvm, jmc)
- Prefer immutability and object pooling where suitable

MODULE OVERVIEW

Efficient use of resources for faster, scalable, and reliable applications.

FOCUS

Efficient Use of Resources

OUTCOME

Faster, Scalable Applications

IMPACT

Reliable Systems at Scale

SKILL LEVEL

Intermediate

ESTIMATED TIME

45 Minutes

This module covers how memory is allocated and managed in applications, common memory issues, and techniques to improve performance. You will learn to write code that is both efficient and scalable.

YOU WILL LEARN

- How memory is allocated and deallocated
- Common memory management problems
- Tools and techniques to detect memory issues
- Performance metrics and profiling
- Best practices for writing performant code

KEY TAKEAWAY This module builds the foundation for writing memory-efficient, high-performance Java applications.

KEY TOPICS

Seven core topic areas covered across this module.



Memory Basics

- Stack vs Heap
- Memory Layout



Dynamic Memory Allocation

- Allocation
- Deallocation
- Lifetimes



Memory Management Issues

- Leaks
- Unclosed Resources
- Fragmentation



Performance Fundamentals

- Time Complexity
- Space Complexity



Performance Profiling

- Profilers
- Benchmarks
- Metrics



Optimization Techniques

- Algorithmic, code, memory, and I/O optimizations.



Best Practices

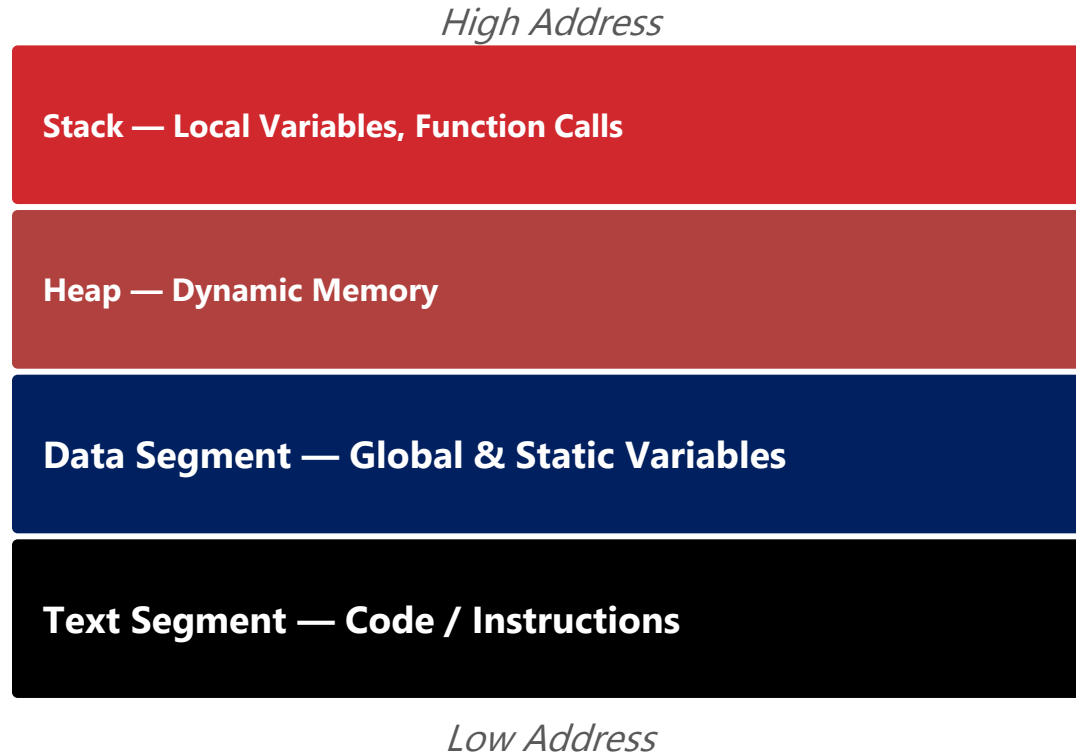
- Patterns and Guidelines

KEY TAKEAWAY Every topic in this list gets its own deep-dive later in the module.

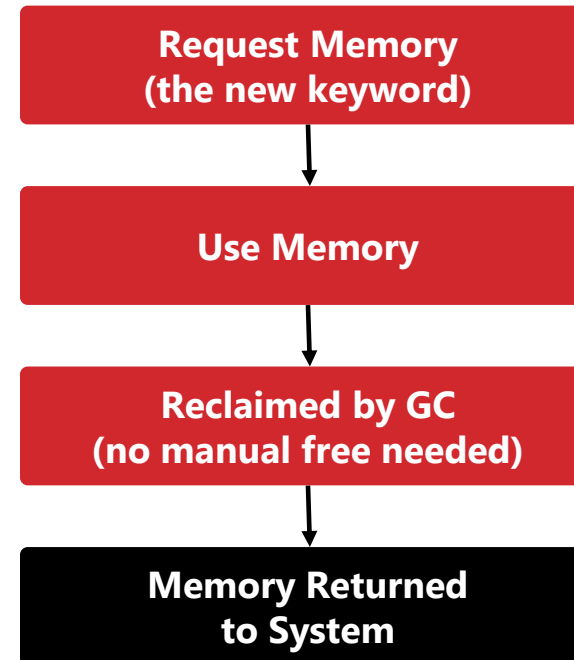
MEMORY MODEL OVERVIEW

How a running process organizes memory, and the lifecycle of a single allocation.

PROCESS MEMORY LAYOUT



MEMORY MANAGEMENT FLOW



KEY TAKEAWAY Every allocation follows the same lifecycle: request, use, release, and return to the system.

COMMON ISSUES & OPTIMIZATION AREAS

A quick preview — both topics are covered in full depth later in this module.

COMMON MEMORY ISSUES



Memory Leaks

Memory is allocated but never freed.



Unclosed Resources

Files, sockets, or connections left open after use.



Buffer Overflows

Writing beyond the bounds of allocated memory.



Memory Fragmentation

Free memory is broken into small unusable chunks.

PERFORMANCE OPTIMIZATION AREAS



Algorithm Efficiency

Choose the right algorithm and data structure.



Memory Efficiency

Minimize allocations, reuse memory.



Code Efficiency

Avoid unnecessary work, reduce overhead.



I/O Efficiency

Batch operations, use async where possible.



Concurrency

Use multitasking to improve throughput.

KEY TAKEAWAY Poor memory management is the root cause behind most of these performance issues.

TOOLS & TECHNIQUES

The toolbox used throughout this module to detect issues and measure performance.



Profilers

VisualVM, JProfiler, YourKit, Java Flight Recorder



Memory Debuggers

Eclipse MAT, VisualVM, jhat



Benchmarking

JMH (Java Microbenchmark Harness)



Monitoring

Memory usage, CPU, GC, I/O metrics



Logging & Analysis

Analyze patterns and bottlenecks.

KEY TAKEAWAY Measuring with the right tool is always the first step — never guess where the bottleneck is.

BEST PRACTICES & LAB HIGHLIGHTS

General guidelines for this module, and a preview of the hands-on labs.



Best Practices

- Allocate only what you need.
- Release memory you no longer use.
- Avoid global mutable state.
- Prefer try-with-resources for closeable resources.
- Profile before you optimize.
- Measure, analyze, and iterate.



Lab Highlights

- Allocate objects and observe automatic garbage collection.
- Detect and fix memory leaks using tools.
- Profile application and identify bottlenecks.
- Optimize code and measure performance improvements.

KEY TAKEAWAY Good memory management is the foundation of high performance and system stability.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What you should walk away with before diving into the details.

- Understand how memory is managed in your application.
- Identify and fix common memory-related issues.
- Use tools to profile and improve performance.
- Write efficient, scalable, and reliable code.

REAL-WORLD IMPACT

Efficient memory usage leads to faster applications, lower resource consumption, and better user experience.

KEY TAKEAWAY Good memory management is the foundation of high performance and system stability.

WHY MEMORY MANAGEMENT MATTERS

Memory is a finite resource — how you allocate, use, and release it directly shapes performance, reliability, cost, and code quality.



1. Better Performance

- Reduces CPU overhead (e.g., GC, paging)
- Faster response times and higher throughput



2. Higher Reliability

- Prevents leaks, overflows, and corruption
- Reduces crashes and unpredictable behavior



3. Scalability

- Handles more users and data
- Critical for cloud-native, distributed systems



4. Cost Efficiency

- Efficient apps do more with less hardware
- Saves money in cloud and on-prem environments



5. Better User Experience

- Fewer slowdowns and crashes
- Directly impacts adoption and retention



6. Foundation for Good Code

- Forces clean, thoughtful code
- Encourages the right data structures and lifetimes

KEY TAKEAWAY Memory discipline is a business enabler, not just a technical detail.

WHAT CAN GO WRONG?

Five failure modes that stem directly from poor memory management.



Memory Leaks

Never freed, eventually exhausting system resources.



Buffer Overflows

Can crash the app or open security holes.



Fragmentation

Broken into small chunks that can't be used efficiently.



Performance Degradation

High memory usage causes swapping and slow response.



System Instability

Out-of-memory errors can terminate processes.

"Good memory management is not just a technical detail — it's a business enabler. It improves performance, reduces costs, increases reliability, and creates better experiences for users."

KEY TAKEAWAY Treat memory management as a first-class engineering concern, not an afterthought.

STACK VS HEAP ALLOCATION

Two different memory regions with different allocation strategies and use cases.



Stack (Automatic)

Managed automatically by the system, follows LIFO order.



Heap (Dynamic)

Managed automatically by the JVM's garbage collector; more flexible, slower.

BEST PRACTICE

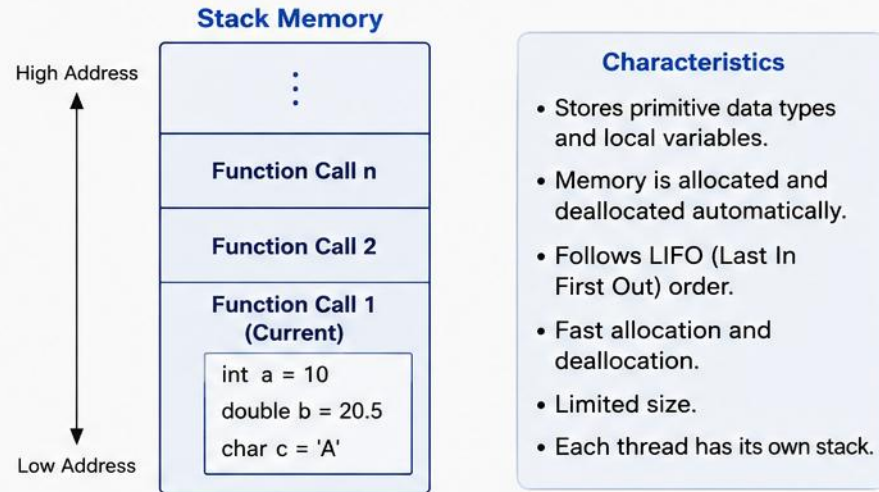
Use stack by default for small, short-lived data. Use heap only when necessary, and release references you no longer need so the garbage collector can reclaim them.

KEY TAKEAWAY The choice between stack and heap is a trade-off between speed and flexibility.

STACK vs HEAP ALLOCATION

Stack and Heap are memory regions used by a program at runtime for different purposes.

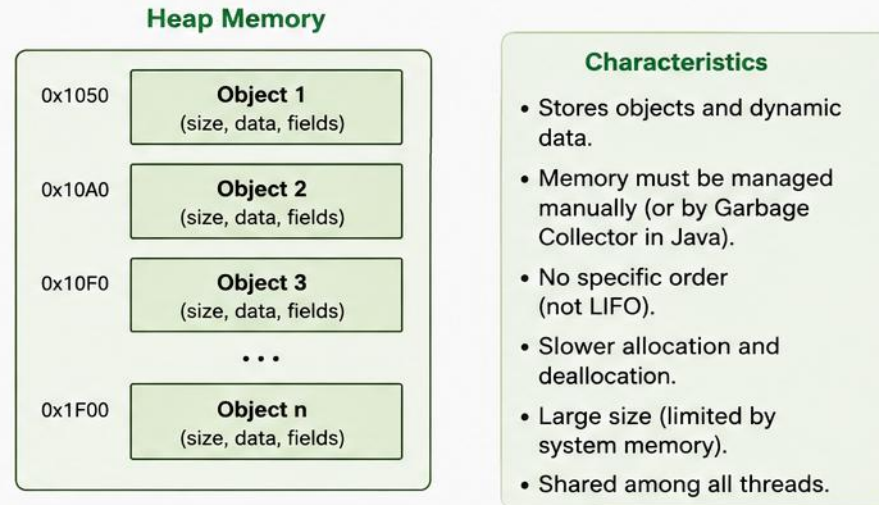
STACK (Automatic Allocation)



Example (Java)

```
void method() {  
    int a = 10;           // stored on Stack  
    double b = 20.5;      // stored on Stack  
    MyClass obj = new MyClass(); // reference on Stack  
                           // object on Heap  
}
```

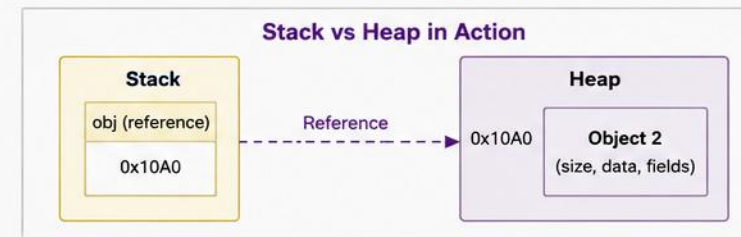
HEAP (Dynamic Allocation)



Example (Java)

```
void method() {  
    MyClass obj = new MyClass(); // obj reference on Stack  
                                // MyClass object on Heap  
}
```

Aspect	Stack	Heap
Allocation	Automatic	Manual (or GC manages)
Deallocation	Automatic	Manual (or GC manages)
Speed	Faster	Slower
Size	Limited (MBs)	Large (GBs)
Access	Direct	Through reference
Used For	Primitive types, local variables, method calls	Objects, arrays, dynamic memory



Key Takeaway: Stack is used for quick, temporary data. Heap is used for objects and data that need to live beyond the current scope.

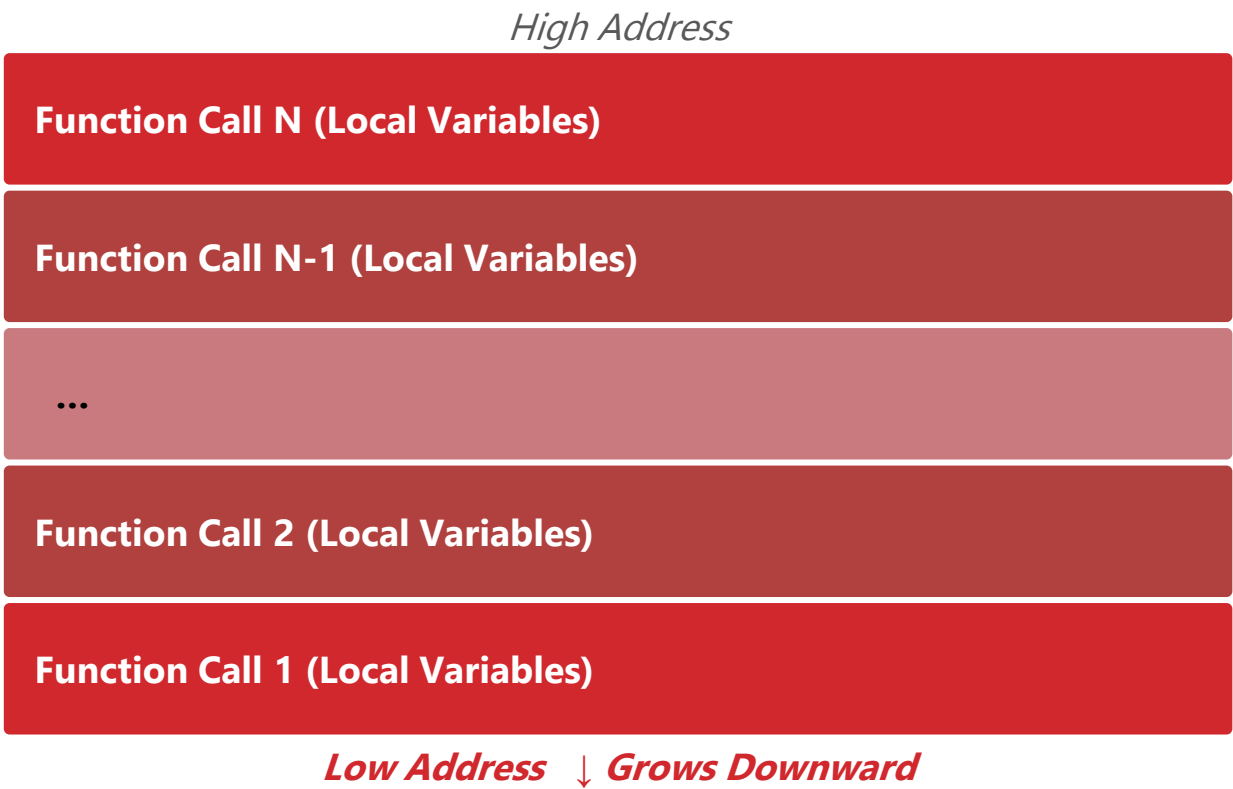
STACK (AUTOMATIC ALLOCATION)

Memory is managed automatically by the system, following LIFO order. (1 of 2)

HOW IT WORKS

- Allocated when a function is called.
- Deallocated when the function returns.
- Very fast allocation and deallocation.
- Size must be known at compile time.

PROPERTY	STACK
Speed	Very Fast
Management	Automatic
Size	Limited (KBs–MBs)
Lifetime	While function is active



KEY TAKEAWAY Each function call pushes a new frame onto the stack; returning pops it back off.

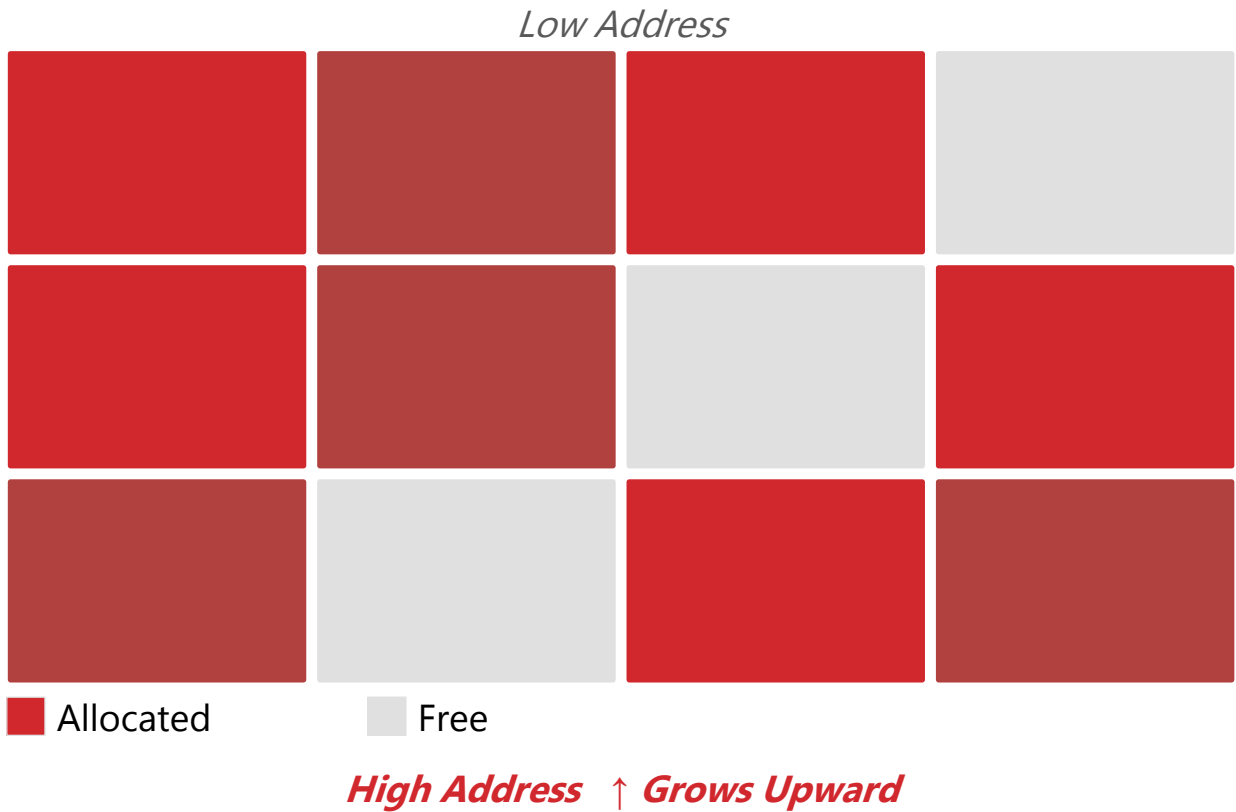
HEAP (DYNAMIC ALLOCATION)

Memory is allocated with new and reclaimed automatically by the garbage collector — more flexible but slower than the stack. (2 of 2)

HOW IT WORKS

- Allocated explicitly with the new keyword.
- Reclaimed automatically by the garbage collector (GC).
- Size can be determined at runtime.
- Risk of leaks if not managed properly.

PROPERTY	HEAP
Speed	Slower (overhead)
Management	Automatic (GC)
Size	Large (system memory)
Lifetime	Until unreachable, then GC'd



KEY TAKEAWAY Unlike the stack, heap blocks are allocated and freed in any order, which is what causes fragmentation.

KEY DIFFERENCES

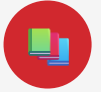
Stack and heap side by side, across every dimension that matters.

ASPECT	STACK	HEAP
Allocation	Automatic	Explicit (new)
Deallocation	Automatic	Automatic (GC)
Speed	Faster	Slower
Size	Limited	Large
Lifetime	Function Scope	Program Scope
Fragmentation	None	Possible
Direction	Grows Down	Grows Up

KEY TAKEAWAY Stack trades flexibility for speed; heap trades speed for flexibility.

WHEN TO USE WHICH?

Choosing between stack and heap comes down to size, lifetime, and speed requirements.



When to Use Stack

- Size is known at compile time.
- For short-lived data.
- For function calls and local variables.
- When speed is critical.



When to Use Heap

- Size is not known until runtime.
- For large objects and complex structures.
- When data needs to outlive the function.
- When flexibility matters more than speed.

KEY TAKEAWAY Unmanaged heap memory can lead to memory leaks, fragmentation, and application crashes.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 1: STACK VS HEAP BASICS

Reinforces: what lives on the stack vs. the heap, as just covered.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Write a tiny program with local variables plus one new object; note what lives on stack vs. heap
2	Do this	Print the object's field, then write a 2-4 sentence observation
3	Key concept	Local variables and references live on the stack; the object itself lives on the heap
4	Reference	exercises/exercise-01-stack-vs-heap.md

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 1 before continuing — see [exercises/exercise-01-stack-vs-heap.md](#).

OBJECT LIFECYCLE IN JAVA

Java uses automatic memory management through Garbage Collection (GC) — every object follows the same six-step lifecycle.



1. Creation

- Created using the new keyword.
- `MyClass obj = new MyClass();`



2. Initialization

- Memory allocated, constructor called.
- Fields set to default values first.



3. In Use

- Referenced by one or more variables.
- Methods called, fields read/modified.



4. No Longer Referenced

- References removed (or set to null).
- Becomes eligible for GC.



5. Eligible for GC

- JVM marks it eligible for GC.
- May still exist in the heap until GC runs.



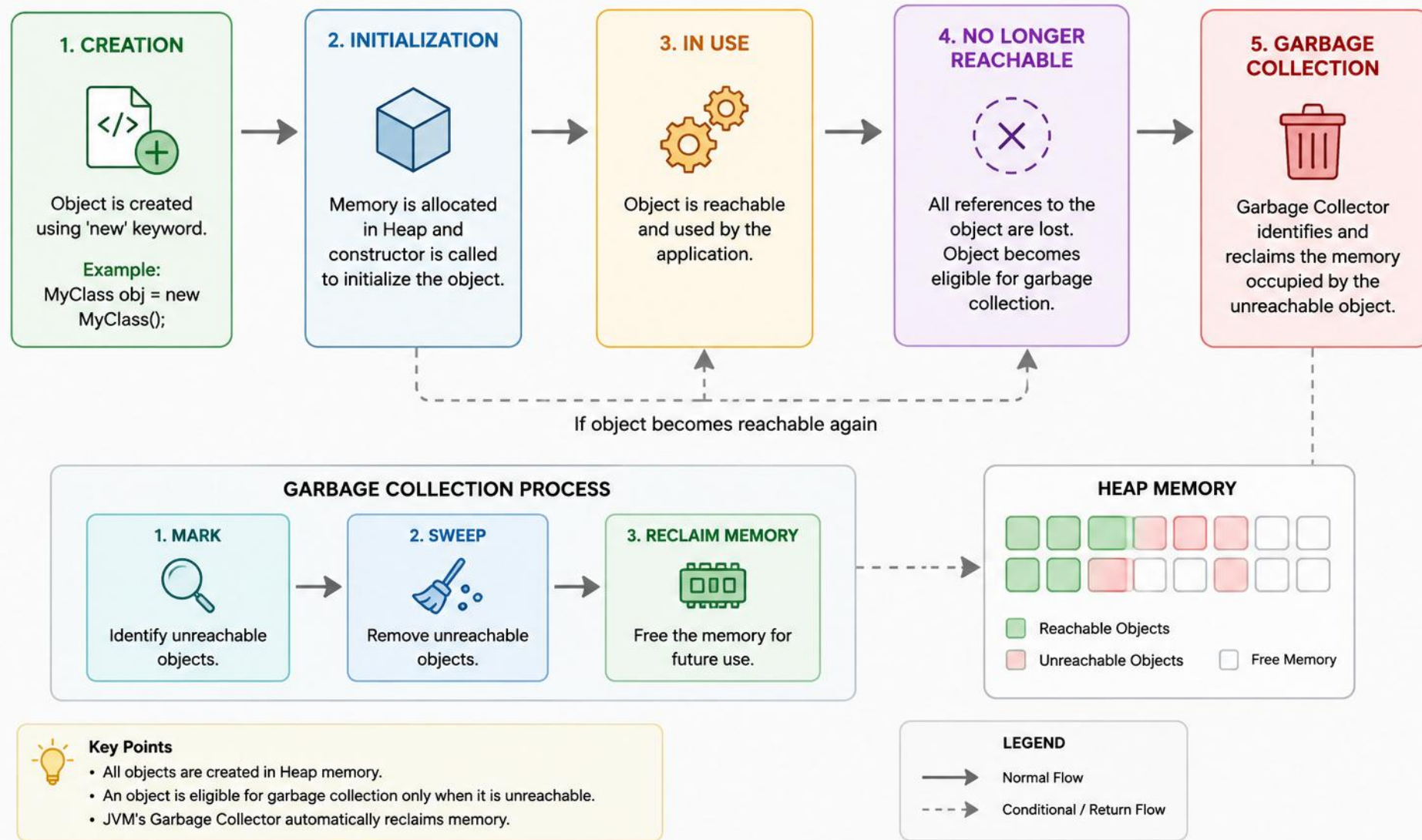
6. Garbage Collected

- GC reclaims the object's memory.
- Memory is freed and reused.

KEY TAKEAWAY GC does not run immediately — it runs automatically in the background when needed.

OBJECT LIFECYCLE IN JAVA

The life of an object from creation to garbage collection



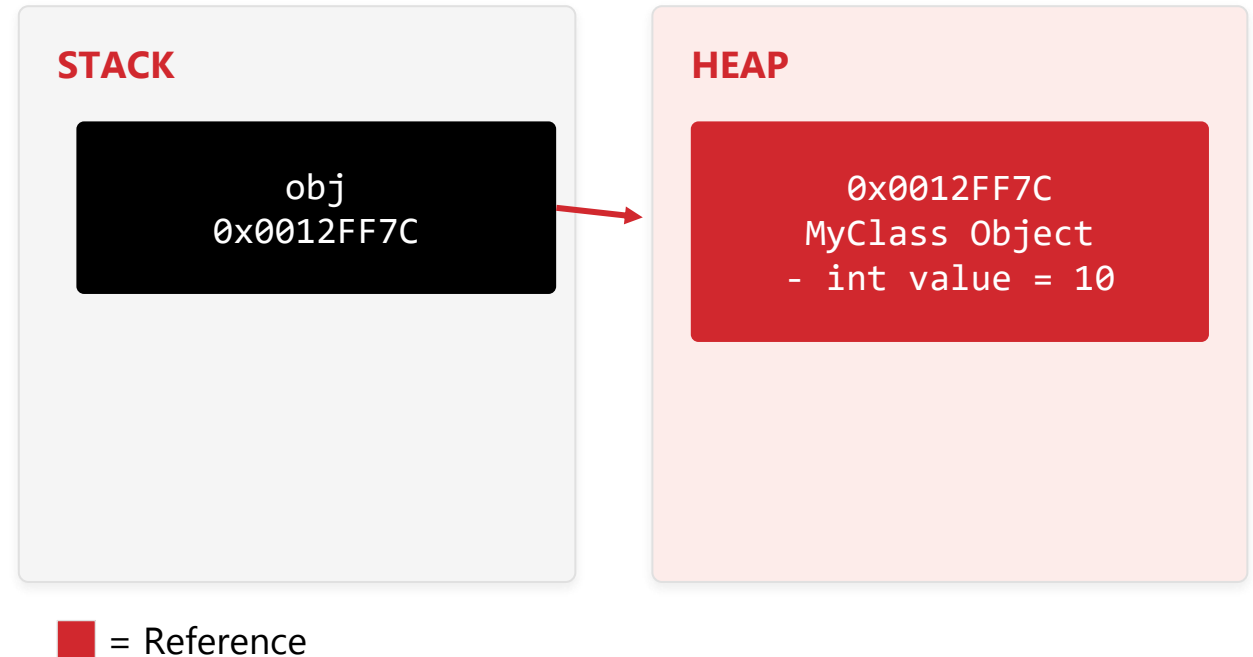
EXAMPLE FLOW: WHERE DOES THE OBJECT LIVE?

The full lifecycle in code, and the stack reference that points to it on the heap.

```
MyClass obj = new MyClass(); // 1. Creation
obj.setValue(10);           // 2. Init
obj.doWork();               // 3. In Use
obj = null;                 // 4. No Longer
Ref'd
// eligible for GC          // 5. Eligible
// GC reclaims when it runs // 6. Collected
```

System.gc() only suggests garbage collection — the JVM decides when it actually runs.

WHERE DOES THE OBJECT LIVE?



KEY TAKEAWAY The stack stores references (variables); the heap stores the actual objects they point to.

KEY POINTS & BEST PRACTICES

What to remember about how Java manages object memory.



Automatic Management

- Java handles allocation & deallocation via GC.



Reachability

- Unreachable objects are eligible for GC.



No Destructors

- Use try-with-resources or finally instead.



System.gc()

- Only a suggestion — the JVM decides.

- Avoid memory leaks by releasing references.
- Close resources properly.
- Profile memory usage in large applications.
- Trust the GC, but write clean code.

KEY TAKEAWAY Remove references when objects are no longer needed to make them eligible for GC sooner.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 2: OBJECT LIFECYCLE

Reinforces: object reachability and lifecycle, as just covered.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Create objects, null a reference, optionally call System.gc(); describe reachability
2	Do this	Object → reference → null, then write observation notes
3	Key concept	An object becomes eligible for GC once no reachable reference points to it
4	Reference	exercises/exercise-02-lifecycle.md

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 2 before continuing — see [exercises/exercise-02-lifecycle.md](#).

GARBAGE COLLECTION TRIGGERS

GC in Java is automatic, but it is not random — it's triggered by specific conditions in the JVM.

1 Allocation Failure

- JVM cannot find sufficient memory.
- The most common trigger.

2 Heap Threshold Reached

- Used heap exceeds a set threshold.
- Via -
XX:InitiatingHeapOccupancyPercent

3 System.gc() / Runtime.gc()

- App explicitly requests GC.
- Only a suggestion, not guaranteed.

4 Full GC Requested by JVM

- Based on internal heuristics.
- E.g., fragmentation, promotion failures.

5 Metaspace Threshold Reached

- Class metadata storage nearly full.
- Common with dynamic class loading.

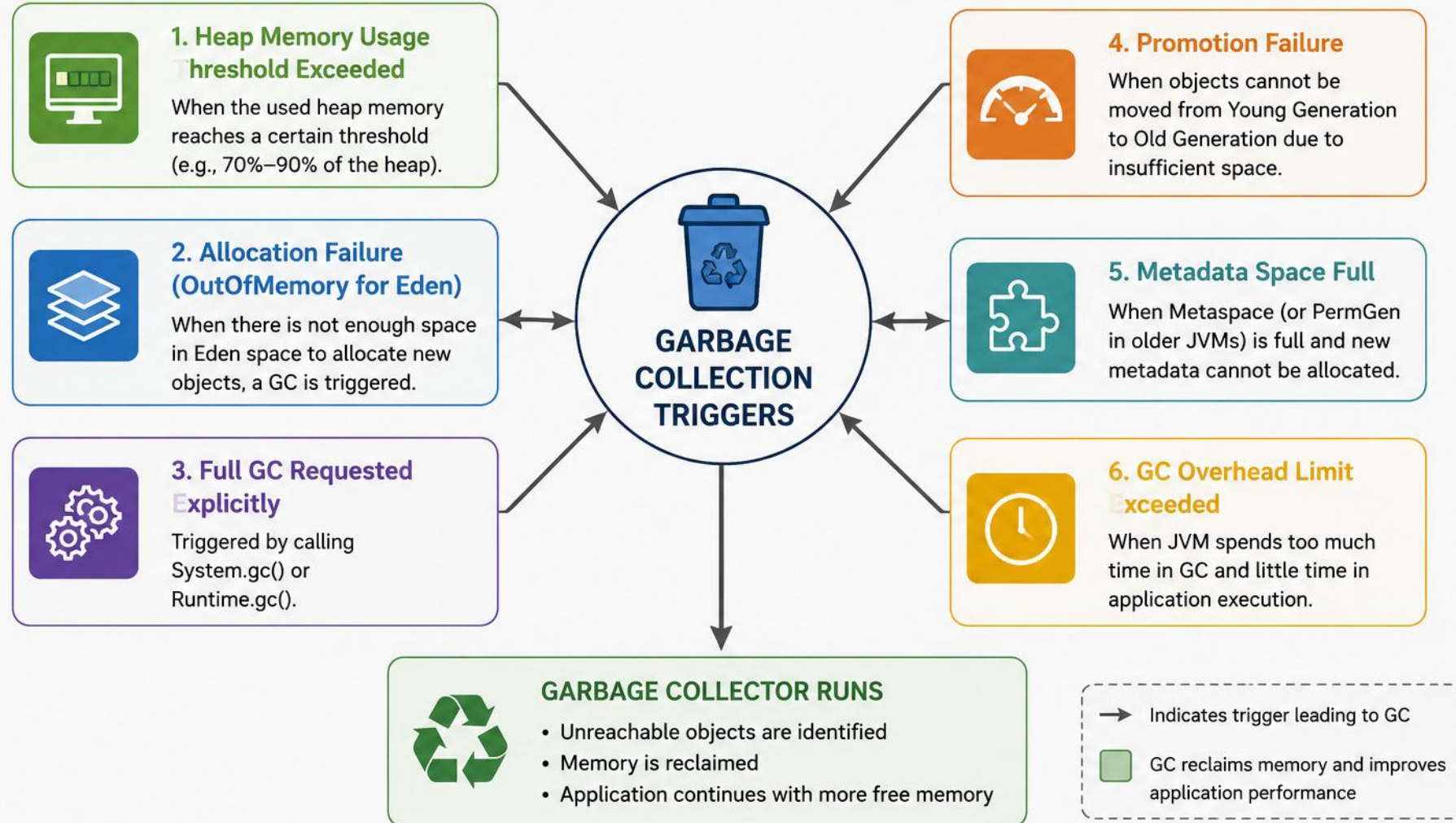
6 Minor GC (Young Gen)

- Triggered when Eden Space fills up.
- Part of Generational GC.

KEY TAKEAWAY Most GC activity in a healthy application is routine Minor GC on the young generation.

GARBAGE COLLECTION TRIGGERS

Garbage Collection in the JVM runs automatically when certain conditions occur to reclaim memory and maintain performance.



TYPES OF GC TRIGGERS

Automatic triggers come from the JVM itself; explicit triggers come from your code or tools.



Automatic Triggers

- Allocation failure
- Heap / Metaspace thresholds
- JVM heuristics (promotion failure, fragmentation)



Explicit Triggers

- System.gc() or Runtime.gc() (JVM may ignore)
- JMX or monitoring tools invoking GC

GC DOES NOT RUN WHEN...

- There is still enough free memory and no threshold is crossed.
- Objects are merely unreachable — that alone doesn't trigger GC.
- Immediately after System.gc() is called, or while a stop-the-world event is already in progress.
- During critical JVM operations (e.g., class loading, biased locking).

KEY TAKEAWAY Unreachable objects wait for GC to run — they are not reclaimed the instant they become unreachable.

EXAMPLE SCENARIO

How a real application progresses from routine allocation to a possible `OutOfMemoryError`.



- Let the JVM manage GC — avoid calling `System.gc()` in production.
- Monitor memory usage and GC activity.
- Tune heap sizes and GC settings based on workload.
- Write memory-efficient code to reduce unnecessary object creation.

KEY TAKEAWAY GC is about reclaiming unused memory at the right time to keep your application fast and stable.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 3: GARBAGE COLLECTION IN ACTION

Reinforces: the GC triggers you just saw.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Allocate in a loop; run with a small heap; capture evidence that GC activity occurred
2	Command	<code>java -Xmx64m YourApp</code>
3	Key concept	A small <code>-Xmx</code> forces GC to run sooner and more often — makes it observable
4	Reference	<code>exercises/exercise-03-gc-observe.md</code>

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 3 before continuing — see `exercises/exercise-03-gc-observe.md`.

G1 GARBAGE COLLECTOR

A modern, server-oriented garbage collector designed for large heap sizes with predictable pause times.

GOAL

High throughput, predictable low pause times

TYPE

Server-side, mostly concurrent, generational GC

INTRODUCED

JDK 7 (experimental), JDK 9+ (default)

BEST FOR

Large heaps (multi-GB+), low latency



Region Based

- Equal-sized regions (1–32 MB); act as Eden, Survivor, or Old.



Mostly Concurrent

- Most work runs with the app; only short pauses for key phases.



Predictable Pauses

- Keeps pauses within a target, tuned via -XX:MaxGCPauseMillis.



Garbage First

- Collects most-garbage regions first, reclaiming space efficiently.



Generational

- Young and Old gens, optimized for short-lived objects.



Flexible

- Adapts to app behavior and available resources automatically.

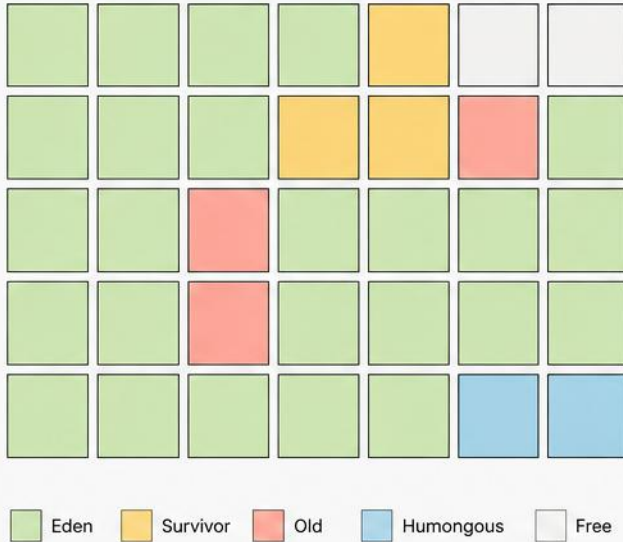
KEY TAKEAWAY “Garbage First” is where G1 gets its name — it always collects the most valuable regions first.

G1 GARBAGE COLLECTOR

Garbage-First, Region-Based, Low-Pause Garbage Collector in the JVM

1. HEAP STRUCTURE – REGION BASED

The heap is divided into fixed-size regions (1MB – 32MB).
Regions can be of different types.



2. HOW G1 WORKS



Allocation

New objects are allocated in Eden regions.



Region Monitoring

G1 continuously monitors region usage and objects.



Garbage-First Selection

Selects regions with most garbage to reclaim (best cost-benefit).



Evacuation (Copying)

Live objects are copied to other regions.



Update References

References are updated to point to new locations.

3. PAUSE TIME GOAL

G1 aims to keep pause times predictable and within the user-defined goal.



Pause Time Goal

e.g., -XX:MaxGCPauseMillis=200

4. CONCURRENT PHASES

Most of the work is done concurrently with application threads.



Concurrent Marking

Marks live objects in the background.



Concurrent Refinement

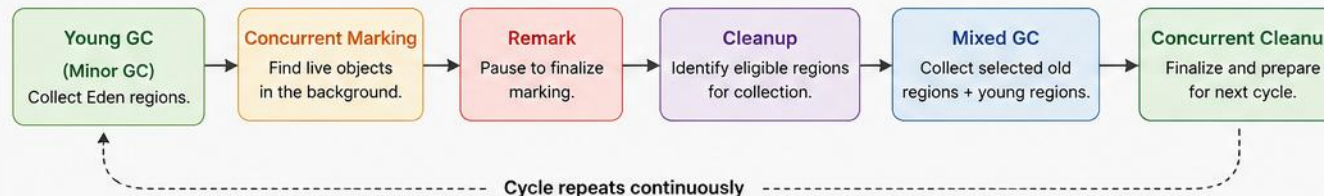
Refines the discovered references.



Concurrent Cleanup

Cleans up regions after collection.

5. G1 COLLECTION CYCLE (TYPICAL FLOW)



6. KEY FEATURES

- ✓ Region-based memory management
- ✓ Predictable low pause times
- ✓ Garbage-first collection strategy
- ✓ Scales well for large heaps (GBs – TBs)
- ✓ Handles humongous objects efficiently



G1 is the default garbage collector in modern Java (Java 9+). It is designed for applications that require high throughput with predictable pause times.

G1 HEAP LAYOUT & GC CYCLE

Regions of equal size adapt roles over time; most of the cycle runs concurrently with your app.

HEAP LAYOUT (REGION BASED)



Eden Survivor Old
Humongous Free

G1 GC CYCLE (HIGH LEVEL)

- 1 Young GC — collects young generation
- 2 Concurrent Marking — marks live objects
- 3 Remark — short STW pause to finish marking
- 4 Cleanup — prepares regions for evacuation
- 5 Mixed GC — collects young + selected old regions

KEY TAKEAWAY Only phases 1, 3, and Mixed GC pause the application — marking and cleanup run concurrently.

WHEN TO USE G1

Weighing G1's advantages against its trade-offs.

- Large heap applications (several GBs to TBs), predictable pause times, fluctuating workloads, multi-core systems — and it's the JDK 9+ default.



Advantages

- Predictable, tunable pause times
- Scales well with heap size
- High throughput, good balance



Considerations

- Slightly higher CPU usage
- Can use more memory than others
- Performance depends on tuning

KEY TAKEAWAY There is no one-size-fits-all G1 configuration — tune based on your specific workload.

G1 — IMPORTANT JVM OPTIONS

The flags you'll actually reach for when tuning G1.

OPTION	PURPOSE
<code>-XX:+UseG1GC</code>	Enable G1 GC (default from JDK 9+)
<code>-XX:MaxGCPauseMillis=<ms></code>	Set target maximum pause time (e.g., 200 ms)
<code>-XX:InitiatingHeapOccupancyPercent</code>	Start concurrent marking at n% heap usage (~45% default)
<code>-Xms</code> / <code>-Xmx</code>	Set initial and maximum heap size
<code>-Xlog:gc* (JDK 9+)</code>	Unified GC logging

KEY TAKEAWAY Monitor GC logs and metrics, and set realistic pause-time goals — too low a target reduces throughput.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 4: G1 COLLECTOR FLAG

Reinforces: the G1 collector you just saw.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Run a short program with -XX:+UseG1GC and record the command
2	Command	<code>java -XX:+UseG1GC YourApp</code>
3	Key concept	G1 is the JVM's default collector since Java 9 — this flag makes the choice explicit
4	Reference	<code>exercises/exercise-04-g1.md</code>

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 4 before continuing — see `exercises/exercise-04-g1.md`.

ZGC OVERVIEW

A scalable, low-latency garbage collector designed for modern, large-heap applications.

GOAL

Extremely low pause times
(sub-millisecond)

TYPE

Server-side, concurrent, non-
generational GC

INTRODUCED

JDK 11 (experimental), JDK 15
(production)

BEST FOR

Very large heaps (multi-TB),
low latency



Ultra-Low Pause Times

- Pause times below 10 ms, typically well under 1 ms.



Scalable

- Handles hundreds of GBs, up to multiple TBs.



Concurrent by Design

- Most work runs concurrently with the application.



No Generations

- Entire heap as a single space; no young/old split.



Load Barriers

- Colored pointers + load barriers track state with minimal overhead.



Region Based

- Fixed-size regions (2 MB) for efficient management.

KEY TAKEAWAY ZGC keeps relocating objects and remapping pointers concurrently to avoid long pauses.

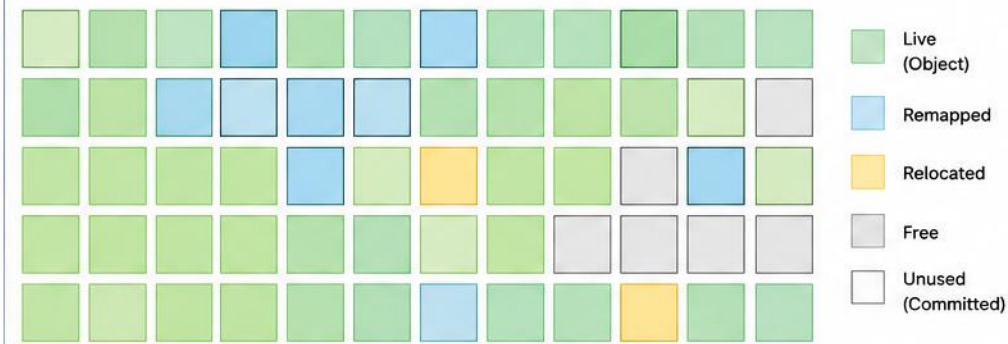
ZGC (Z Garbage Collector) – Java

Ultra-low pause, scalable garbage collector for large heaps (TB scale)

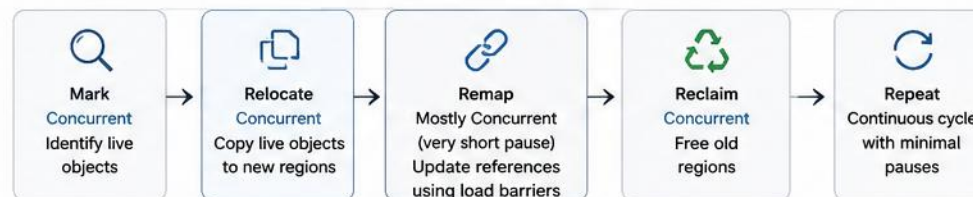
Key Characteristics

-  **Ultra-Low Pause Times**
Pauses < 10ms (typically 1–2ms)
-  **Scales to Multi-TB Heaps**
Designed for very large memory
-  **Concurrent & Parallel**
Most of the work is done concurrently with the application
-  **Load Barriers**
Ensures memory consistency with colored pointers
-  **High Throughput**
Low pause with strong application throughput

ZGC Heap (Region Based)



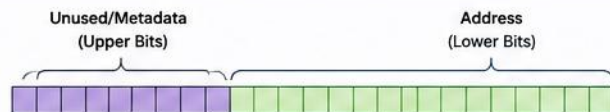
ZGC Execution Phases



How ZGC Works

- 1 Mark**
Concurrent marking identifies live objects.
- 2 Relocate**
Live objects are copied to new regions concurrently.
- 3 Remap**
Pointers to moved objects are updated using load barriers.
- 4 Reclaim**
Old regions are freed and returned to the free list.
- 5 Repeat**
Process runs continuously with very short pauses.

Load Barriers (Colored Pointers)



Used by ZGC to keep track of object location state

Colors represent pointer state

- | Color | State |
|-------------|------------------------|
| 00 (Green) | Finalizable (Normal) |
| 01 (Blue) | Remapped (Needs remap) |
| 10 (Yellow) | Marked |
| 11 (Red) | Weakly reachable |

ZGC Architecture



Benefits

-  **Pauses < 10ms**
Consistent low latency
-  **Scales to TBs**
Handles very large heaps efficiently
-  **High Throughput**
Designed for production workloads
-  **Stable & Predictable**
Low latency with high reliability

Use Cases

- Large heap applications (100GB – Multi-TB)
- Low latency services
- Microservices, Real-time analytics, Trading systems
- Cloud-native and containerized workloads

ZGC HEAP LAYOUT & CYCLE

ZGC continuously relocates live objects and remaps pointers, working in small steps to keep pauses minimal.

HEAP LAYOUT (REGION BASED)



■ Live ■ Remapped ■ Relocated
■ Free ■ In Collection

ZGC CYCLE (HIGH LEVEL)

- 1 Mark — concurrent marking to identify live objects
- 2 Relocate — live objects moved to new locations
- 3 Remap — pointers remapped to new locations
- 4 Reclaim — old regions with no live objects reclaimed

Repeat continuously — no full stop-the-world phase.

KEY TAKEAWAY Pause times are mostly under 1 ms, even for very large heaps — ZGC never stops the world for a full collection.

WHEN TO USE ZGC

Weighing ZGC's advantages against its trade-offs.

- Ultra-low latency needs (<1ms pauses), very large heaps, real-time and high-throughput services, and workloads where latency matters more than raw CPU usage.



Advantages

- Consistent, ultra-low pauses
- Scales to very large heaps
- Excellent for latency-sensitive apps



Considerations

- Higher CPU overhead than others
- Needs more metadata memory
- Not optimized for small heaps

KEY TAKEAWAY ZGC trades some CPU overhead for consistent, ultra-low pause times — a good deal for latency-critical services.

ZGC — IMPORTANT JVM OPTIONS

The flags you'll actually reach for when tuning ZGC.

OPTION	PURPOSE
<code>-XX:+UseZGC</code>	Enable ZGC
<code>-Xms<size> -Xmx<size></code>	Set initial and maximum heap size
<code>-XX:ZCollectionInterval=<ms></code>	(Optional) Soft limit for GC interval
<code>-XX:ZUncommitDelay=<s></code>	Delay before returning memory to the OS
<code>-Xlog:gc*,gc+z*=debug</code>	Detailed ZGC logging

KEY TAKEAWAY Always test and tune ZGC with your real workload — use the latest JDK for ongoing improvements.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 5: ZGC FLAG

Reinforces: the ZGC collector you just saw.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Select ZGC explicitly and compare its log against Exercise 4's G1 run
2	Command	<code>java -XX:+UseZGC -Xlog:gc GcObserve</code>
3	Key concept	ZGC does most of its work concurrently — pauses stay tiny even on large heaps
4	Reference	<code>exercises/exercise-05-zgc.md</code>

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 5 before continuing — see `exercises/exercise-05-zgc.md`.

MEMORY LEAKS EXPLAINED

Memory that is no longer needed by the application is not released and becomes unreachable for reuse.



What Is a Memory Leak?

- Objects no longer in use are still referenced.
- This prevents the GC from reclaiming memory.



Why It Matters

- Increased memory usage over time
- Degraded application performance
- OutOfMemoryError (OOM) crashes



How Java Manages Memory

- Objects are created in Heap memory.
- Unreachable objects are collected by GC.
- If still reachable, memory is not freed.

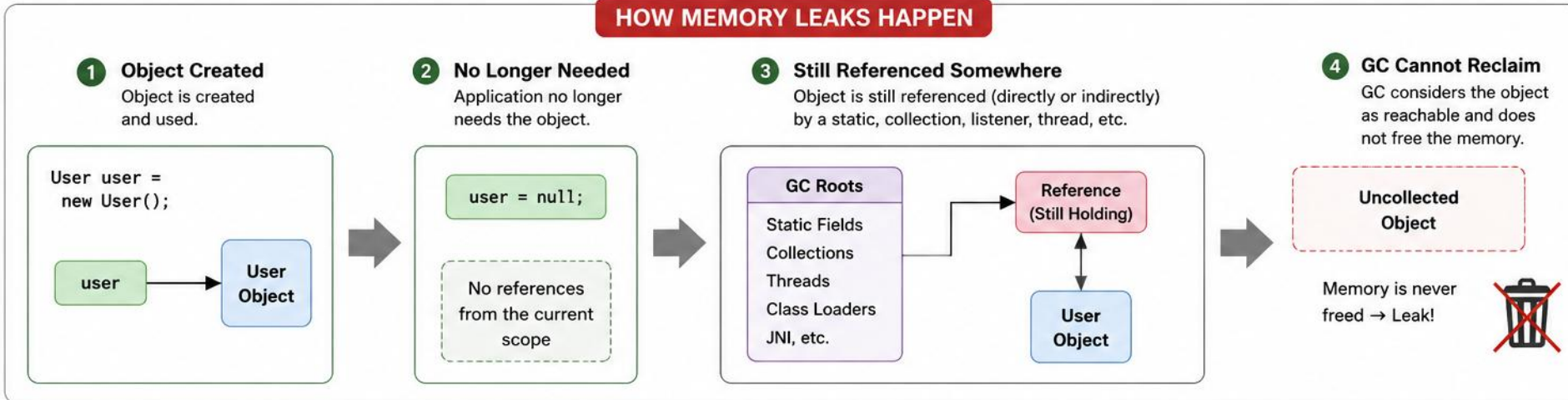
KEY TAKEAWAY A memory leak in Java isn't lost memory — it's memory that's still referenced when it shouldn't be.

MEMORY LEAKS IN JAVA



A memory leak occurs when an application unintentionally retains objects that are no longer needed, preventing Garbage Collector (GC) from reclaiming memory.

HOW MEMORY LEAKS HAPPEN



COMMON CAUSES OF MEMORY LEAKS



Static Collections

Objects added to static collections are never released.



Unclosed Resources

Streams, connections, sockets not closed properly.



Listeners / Callbacks

Listeners registered but not unregistered.



Inner Classes

Non-static inner classes hold implicit reference to outer class.



Thread Local Variables

ThreadLocal values not removed after use.

PREVENTION & DETECTION

BEST PRACTICES

- ✓ Clear collections when no longer needed.
- ✓ Close resources in finally block or try-with-resources.
- ✓ Unregister listeners and callbacks.
- ✓ Use WeakReference / SoftReference where appropriate.
- ✓ Remove ThreadLocal values using `ThreadLocal.remove()`.

DETECTION TOOLS



VisualVM

Monitor heap usage, detect leaks.



Eclipse MAT

Analyze heap dump to find leaks.



JProfiler / YourKit

Identify memory retention paths.



GC Logs (-Xlog:gc*)

Analyze GC behavior and memory usage.



Memory leaks increase memory usage over time, degrade performance, and can eventually lead to **OutOfMemoryError**.

HOW MEMORY LEAKS HAPPEN

Five of the most common causes — all involving cleanup that never happens.



Unintentional References

- Objects still referenced by variables, static fields, or collections.



Static Collections

- Objects added to static collections are never removed.



Cache Without Expiration

- Caches that grow continuously without removing old entries.



Unremoved Listeners / Callbacks

- Listeners hold references even after they're no longer needed.



Resource Not Closed

- Open files, streams, sockets, and DB connections keep resources.

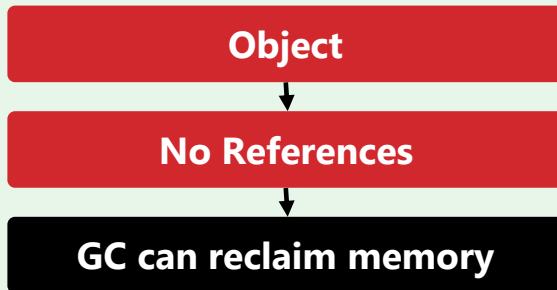
KEY TAKEAWAY Every listener you register and every resource you open is a cleanup obligation.

MEMORY LEAK: EXAMPLE & THE CORE DIFFERENCE

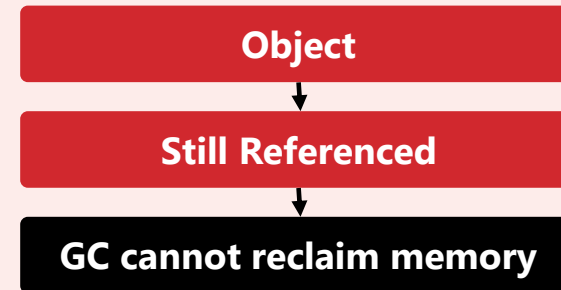
A static list that grows forever, and the one thing that separates a leak from clean collection.

```
public class LeakyService { // static list holds refs forever
    private static List<User> users = new ArrayList<>();
    public void process(User user) {
        users.add(user); // never removed
    }
}
```

NO LEAK



LEAK



KEY TAKEAWAY The JVM can only collect what is unreachable — your code decides what stays reachable.

COMMON MEMORY LEAK SCENARIOS

Six patterns worth watching for in real applications.

SCENARIO	DESCRIPTION
Large Objects	Holding references to large objects when no longer needed.
Static Fields	Static fields keep objects alive for the entire application lifecycle.
Collections	Collections that grow indefinitely without cleanup.
Listeners / Callbacks	Listeners registered but not unregistered.
Unclosed Resources	Files, streams, sockets, DB connections not closed properly.
Cache / Map	Cache without eviction policy (e.g., SimpleCache, HashMap).

KEY TAKEAWAY Most memory-leak scenarios trace back to one root cause: something holds a reference longer than it should.

TOOLS FOR CONFIRMING A LEAK

The toolkit for turning a suspicion into a confirmed diagnosis.



VisualVM

Monitor heap usage and capture heap dumps.



JConsole

Built-in JVM monitoring tool.



Eclipse MAT

Analyze heap dumps for retained objects.



GC Logs

Track heap behavior across collections.

KEY TAKEAWAY Each tool answers a different question: VisualVM/JConsole for live monitoring, Eclipse MAT for post-mortem analysis, GC logs for collection history.

DETECT & PREVENT MEMORY LEAKS

How to find leaks before production, and how to avoid writing them in the first place.



How to Detect

- Monitor heap usage over time (VisualVM, JConsole).
- Take thread dumps and heap dumps.
- Analyze heap dumps in Eclipse MAT or VisualVM.
- Check GC logs for increasing heap after GC.



How to Prevent

- Remove references when objects are no longer needed.
- Use WeakHashMap and WeakReference for caches.
- Clear collections and caches periodically.
- Always close resources — try-with-resources.
- Unregister listeners, callbacks, and observers.

KEY TAKEAWAY If memory keeps growing without reason, you probably have a memory leak — keep heap usage stable over time.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 6: LEAK SKETCH (SAFE)

Reinforces: memory leaks and GC roots, as just covered.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Show a growing static List that retains objects (cap the size — do not OOM)
2	Do this	Stop at e.g. 10,000 entries, then write a root-cause note
3	Key concept	A static field is a GC root — objects it references are never eligible for collection
4	Reference	exercises/exercise-06-leak-sketch.md

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 6 before continuing — see [exercises/exercise-06-leak-sketch.md](#).

DIAGNOSING MEMORY ISSUES

A systematic approach and the right tools help you find the root cause quickly.



Common Symptoms

- High memory usage over time
- Frequent or long GC pauses
- OutOfMemoryError (OOM)
- Slow application / degraded throughput



Goal

- Identify what is consuming memory,
- why it is growing, and how to fix it.



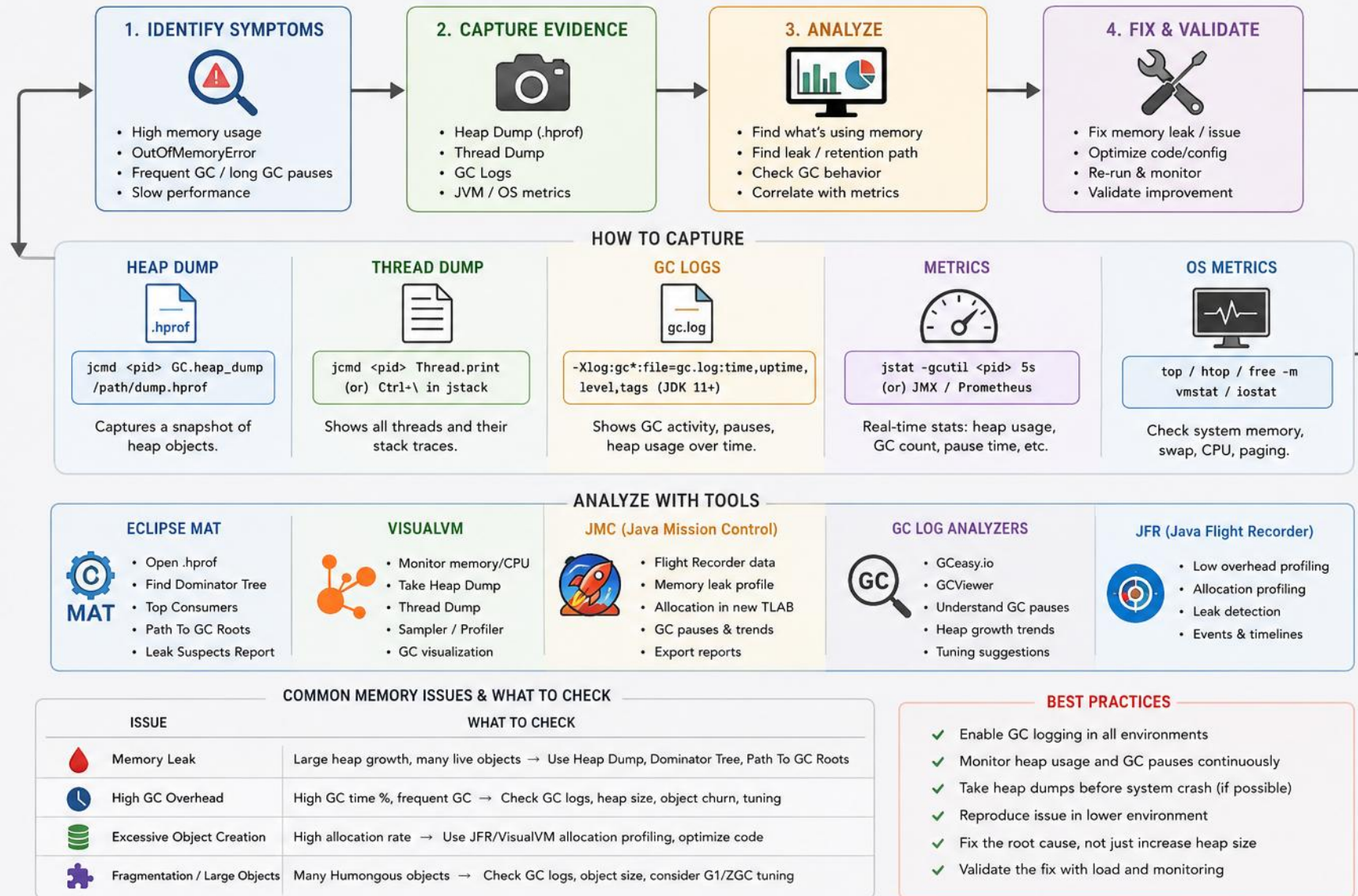
Key Principle

- Measure → Analyze →
- Identify Root Cause → Fix → Validate

KEY TAKEAWAY The JVM manages memory, but your code determines what becomes unreachable.

DIAGNOSING MEMORY ISSUES IN JAVA

Identify the problem → Capture evidence → Analyze → Fix & Validate



STEPS 1-2 — OBSERVE, THEN ANALYZE

Before you can fix a memory problem, gather evidence — then turn it into understanding.



Monitor Metrics

- Heap usage, GC activity, system metrics.
- Tools: VisualVM, JConsole, Prometheus



Check GC Logs

- Heap usage, GC frequency, pause times.
- `-Xlog:gc*` or `-XX:+PrintGCDetails`



Look for Errors & Reproduce

- Check logs for `OutOfMemoryError`.
- Reproduce in a lower environment.



Heap Dumps

- Capture at the time of the issue.
- Analyze with Eclipse MAT, VisualVM



Live Profiling

- Top memory consumers.
- Object allocation rate.



Key Things to Look For

- Large objects / big collections.
- ClassLoader leaks, unbounded caches.

KEY TAKEAWAY You can't fix what you haven't measured — a heap dump is a snapshot, so capture it close to the moment of failure.

STEP 3 — IDENTIFY ROOT CAUSE

Five categories cover almost every memory problem you'll encounter.



Unintended Retention

Static collections, caches, singletons, listeners.



Unbounded Growth

Collections, maps, queues, or caches grow without limits.



Resource Leaks

Files, sockets, DB connections, streams not closed.



Incorrect Cache Usage

No eviction policy, or extremely large caches.



Poor Lifecycle Mgmt.

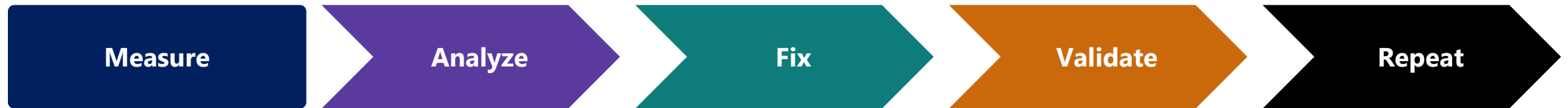
Objects kept longer than necessary.

KEY TAKEAWAY Root cause almost always comes down to something being kept alive longer than it needs to be.

STEP 4 — FIX, VALIDATE & REPEAT

Diagnosis is only half the job — closing the loop is what makes the fix stick.

- Remove unnecessary references; use appropriate data structures and limits.
- Close resources with finally blocks or try-with-resources; implement cache eviction policies.
- Optimize object lifecycle and clean up listeners, threads, etc.; redeploy and monitor to verify.



KEY TAKEAWAY Diagnosing memory issues is a continuous improvement cycle, not a one-time fix.

USEFUL JVM OPTIONS & POPULAR DIAGNOSTIC TOOLS

The flags and the tools most Java teams reach for when investigating a memory issue.

JVM OPTIONS

OPTION	PURPOSE
<code>-Xms / -Xmx</code>	Initial and maximum heap size
<code>-XX:+HeapDumpOnOutOfMemoryError</code>	Generate heap dump on OOM
<code>-XX:HeapDumpPath=<path></code>	Heap dump file location
<code>-Xlog:gc* (JDK 9+)</code>	Unified GC logging
<code>-XX:NativeMemoryTracking</code>	Track native memory usage

POPULAR TOOLS

TOOL	PURPOSE
VisualVM	Monitor, profile, heap dumps
Eclipse MAT	Analyze heap dumps
JConsole	JMX monitoring
JProfiler / YourKit	Advanced profiling
GCViewer	Analyze GC logs

KEY TAKEAWAY Configure heap-dump-on-OOM in every production environment — you only get one chance to capture it.

JAVA PERFORMANCE FUNDAMENTALS

Write efficient code. Use resources wisely. Understand what the JVM is doing.

CORE PRINCIPLES



Performance is a Feature

Fast apps deliver better UX and lower costs.



Measure, Don't Guess

Use metrics and profiling to find real bottlenecks.



Optimize Wisely

Focus on high-impact changes, not micro-optimizations.



Understand Trade-offs

Balance CPU, memory, latency and throughput.



Keep It Simple

Clean code is easier to optimize and less error-prone.

1. KNOW YOUR RESOURCES



CPU

Avoid excessive computation and unnecessary work.



Memory

Avoid large objects, leaks, excessive allocations.



I/O

Disk, network, DB are slower — minimize blocking.



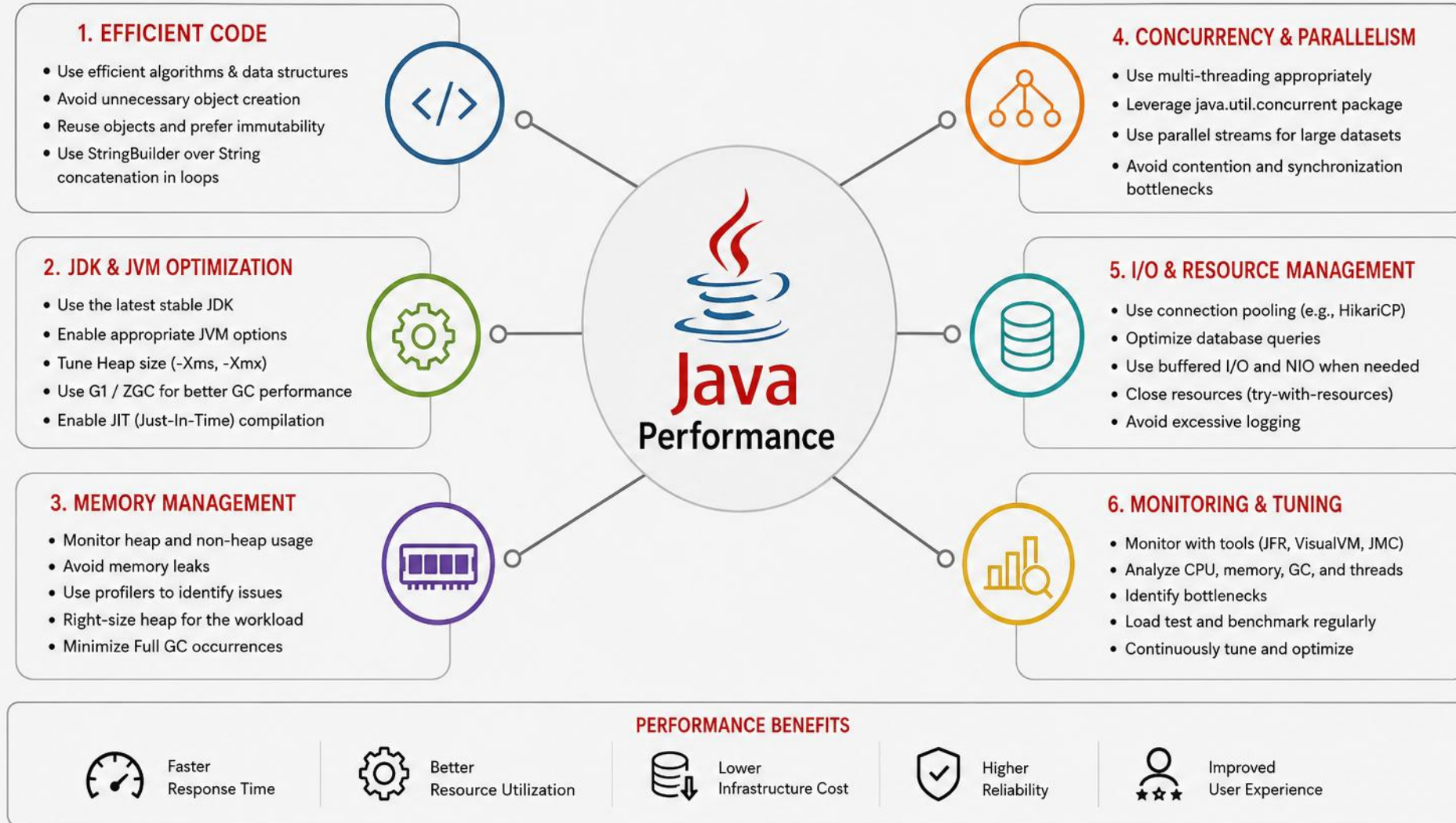
Time

Reduce latency, improve throughput and scalability.

KEY TAKEAWAY Performance work always starts by understanding which resource — CPU, memory, I/O, or time — is the constraint.

JAVA PERFORMANCE

Java performance depends on efficient code, optimized JVM behavior, proper resource management, and right-sizing the infrastructure.



2. WRITE EFFICIENT CODE

Small, everyday choices that compound into real performance gains.



Choose Right Data Structures

- ArrayList over Vector, HashMap over Hashtable
- StringBuilder over + for strings



Avoid Unnecessary Object Creation

- Reuse objects where possible.



Use Primitives, Not Wrappers

- Use int instead of Integer to reduce overhead.



Avoid Excessive Synchronization

- Use concurrent collections.
- Lock only when needed.



Minimize Method Call Overhead

- Keep hot-path methods small.
- Mark final where appropriate.



Prefer Enhanced For-Loop

- Cleaner and potentially optimized.

KEY TAKEAWAY Synchronization and method-call overhead matter most exactly where you can least afford them: hot paths.

3. MANAGE MEMORY WISELY

Most performance problems trace back to memory misuse.



Reduce Object Allocations

- Reuse objects.
- Use object pools (when appropriate).
- Be careful with autoboxing.



Watch for Memory Leaks

- Unclosed resources.
- Static collections holding references.
- Listeners/callbacks not deregistered.



Right-Size the Heap

- Too small → GC pressure, OOM.
- Too large → longer GC pauses.

KEY TAKEAWAY Most performance problems are caused by memory misuse and unnecessary allocations.

4. AVOID COMMON PERFORMANCE ANTI-PATTERNS

Six habits that quietly degrade an otherwise well-designed application.



Premature Optimization

Optimizing before measuring wastes time.



Busy Waiting / Spin Loops

Consumes CPU without doing useful work.



Blocking on Critical Paths

Avoid blocking I/O or DB calls in latency-sensitive code.



Large Synchronized Blocks

Reduces concurrency and throughput.



Unbounded Collections

Collections that grow without limits cause memory issues.



Logging in Hot Paths

Excessive logging slows down the application.

KEY TAKEAWAY Every one of these anti-patterns is easy to introduce accidentally and easy to avoid once you know to look for it.

5. MEASURE & PROFILE

You can't optimize what you don't measure.



Key Metrics

- Response Time / Latency
- Throughput
- CPU Usage
- Memory Usage
- GC Activity
- Error Rate



Tools

- JMH — Microbenchmarking
- VisualVM — Profiling & Monitoring
- Java Flight Recorder (JFR)
- JConsole, GC Logs, YourKit / JProfiler

KEY TAKEAWAY JMH, VisualVM, and JFR cover almost every measurement need a Java developer will have.

6. UNDERSTAND THE JVM

What the JVM already optimizes for you, and how to stay out of its way.



JVM Optimizations

- JIT (Just-In-Time) Compilation
- Escape Analysis
- Inline Caching
- Dead Code Elimination
- Loop Unrolling



What You Can Do

- Write simple, clean code.
- Warm up your application.
- Avoid reflection in hot paths.
- Keep code JIT-friendly.
- Let the JVM do its job.

KEY TAKEAWAY The JVM's JIT compiler does an enormous amount of optimization automatically — clean, simple code helps it help you.

7. EXAMPLE: STRING CONCATENATION

String concatenation in a loop creates many temporary objects — StringBuilder avoids that entirely.

INEFFICIENT

```
String result = "";
for (String s : list) {
    result += s;    // Creates many objects
}
```

EFFICIENT

```
StringBuilder sb = new StringBuilder();
for (String s : list) {
    sb.append(s);
}
String result = sb.toString();
```

- Measure before you optimize; profile in a production-like environment.
- Focus on the bottlenecks, not the whole code; test with real workloads.

KEY TAKEAWAY Use StringBuilder (or StringBuffer) instead of + concatenation inside loops.

TRY IT YOURSELF — EXERCISE 7: STRING VS STRINGBUILDER

Reinforces: the string concatenation example you just saw.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Goal	Compare naive String concat in a loop vs. StringBuilder for $N \approx 50,000$ (timing)
2	Do this	Wrap each loop in <code>System.nanoTime()</code> calls and print the duration
3	Key concept	Each <code>+</code> on a String creates a new object; StringBuilder mutates one buffer instead
4	Reference	<code>exercises/exercise-07-string-vs-builder.md</code>

TRY IT NOW Complete Exercise 7 before continuing — see `exercises/exercise-07-string-vs-builder.md`.

PERFORMANCE TUNING BASICS

Tuning is about removing bottlenecks, using resources efficiently, and getting the best performance for your workload.

CORE PRINCIPLES



Tune Systematically

Measure → Analyze
→ Change → Validate



Measure First

You can't improve
what you don't
measure.



Change One Thing at a Time

Make small changes
and measure the
impact.



Understand Trade-offs

CPU, memory, latency,
and throughput must
balance.



Know Your Workload

Different applications
need different tuning.

1. KNOW YOUR BOTTLENECK



CPU Bound

High CPU, low I/O wait —
check algorithms & locks.



Memory Bound

High GC activity, frequent
pauses, OOM.



I/O Bound

High wait on disk, network, or
database.



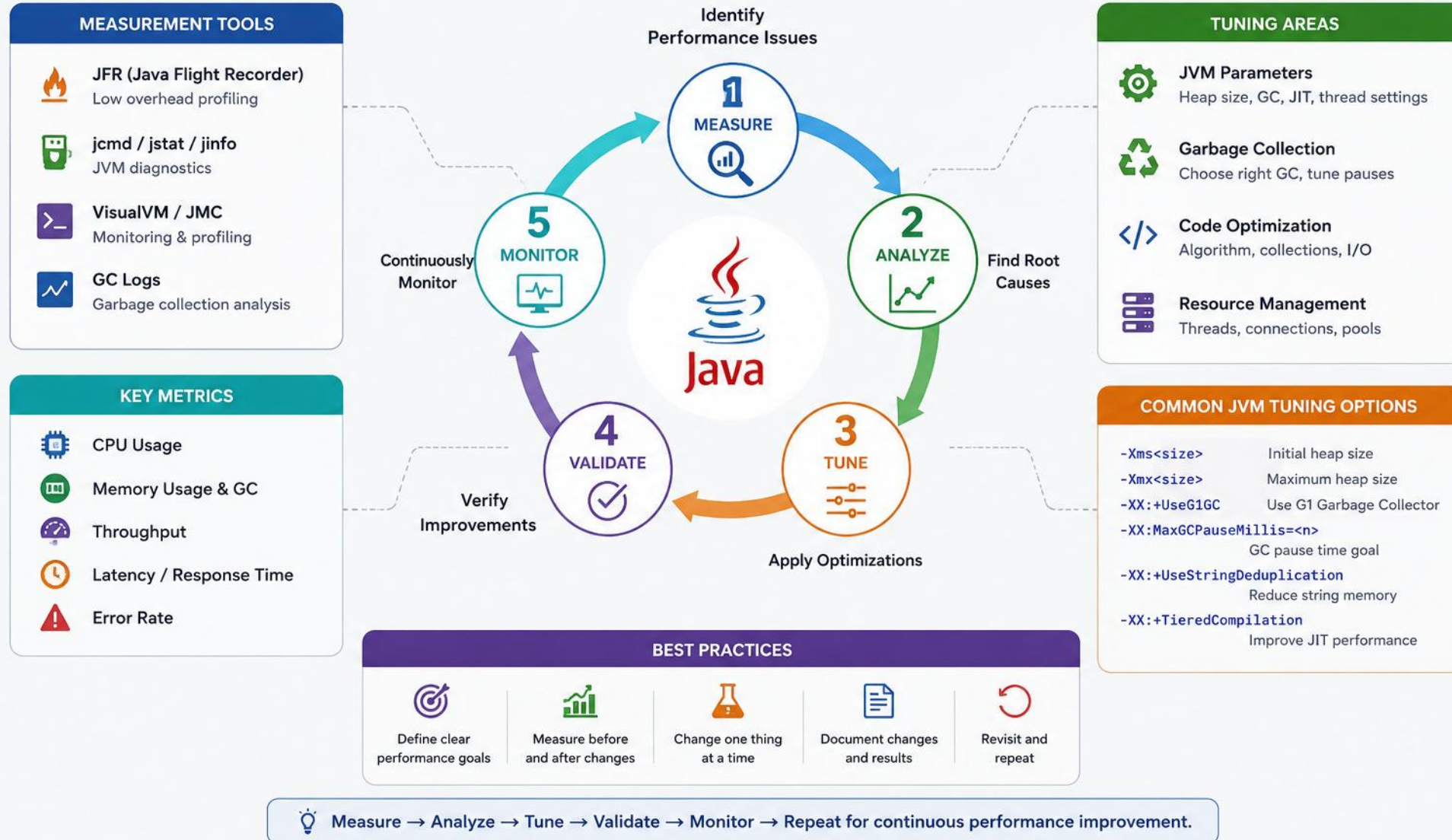
Lock Bound

High blocked time, low CPU
— check contention.

KEY TAKEAWAY Tune systematically: measure, analyze, change one thing at a time, then validate.

JAVA PERFORMANCE TUNING

A Continuous Process for Optimal Performance



2-3. KEY AREAS TO TUNE & JVM BASICS

Five categories cover most real-world tuning work; heap sizing is the single biggest lever.

**Code & Algorithms**
Efficient algorithms; avoid unnecessary work.

**Memory & GC**
Right-size the heap; reduce allocations.

**Data Structures**
Right collection; set initial capacity.

**Concurrency**
Minimize locks; tune thread pools.

**I/O & Resources**
Buffered streams, connection pooling.

HEAP SIZING — set `-Xms/-Xmx` properly. Too small → frequent GC. Too large → long GC pauses.

GC	BEST FOR	CHARACTERISTICS
G1 (default)	Most applications	Balanced throughput and pause times
ZGC	Very large heaps, low latency	Sub-millisecond pauses
Shenandoah	Large heaps, low latency	Concurrent, low pauses
Serial / Parallel	Small heaps, batch jobs	Throughput focused

KEY TAKEAWAY Choosing the right GC for your workload is a bigger lever than almost any other single JVM tuning flag.

4. MEASURE & ANALYZE

The essential toolset for turning tuning into a data-driven exercise.



Essential Tools

- JDK Tools: jcmd, jstat, jmap, jstack, jinfo
- VisualVM: monitor, profile, heap dump
- JFR: low-overhead profiling
- OS Tools: top, vmstat, iostat, netstat



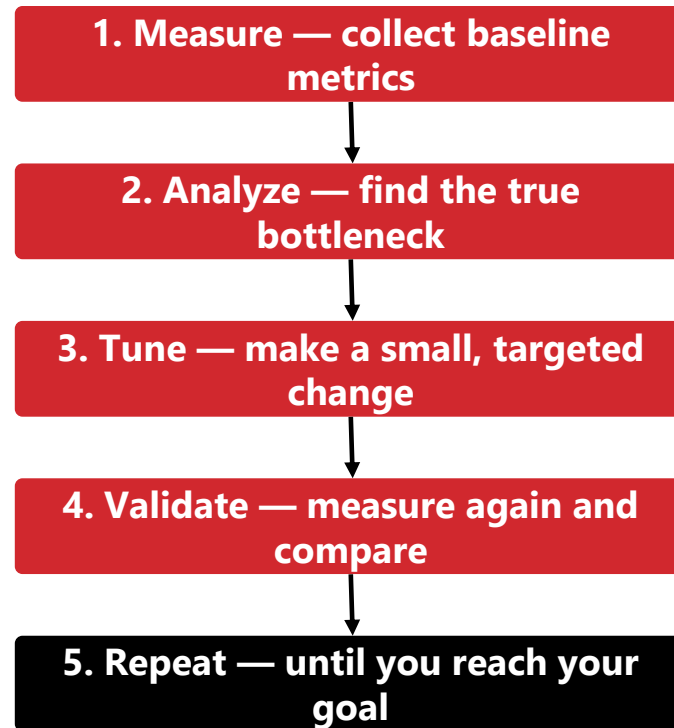
What to Monitor

- Throughput — requests/sec, transactions/sec
- Latency — average, P95, P99
- CPU & memory usage
- I/O, database, network dependencies

KEY TAKEAWAY Ask the right question for each metric: is throughput meeting goals? Are response times acceptable?

5. TUNING WORKFLOW

The same five-step loop, every time you tune.



KEY TAKEAWAY The best tuning is the one that solves the real bottleneck with the least complexity.

6. QUICK TUNING CHECKLIST

Eight items worth reviewing on every performance pass.



Heap & GC

- Right-size heap (-Xms and -Xmx)
- Use the right GC for your workload



Code & Data

- Review and optimize hot code paths
- Reduce object creation and large objects
- Choose appropriate data structures



Concurrency & I/O

- Tune thread pools and concurrency
- Use connection pooling and caching
- Monitor, analyze, iterate

KEY TAKEAWAY Get it working correctly first, then tune — always in a production-like environment with real data.

7. GOOD PRACTICES

Closing guidance to keep tuning disciplined and repeatable.

- Get it working correctly first, then tune.
- Profile in an environment similar to production, with production-like data and load.
- Document every change and its impact.
- Avoid premature optimization; continuously monitor after deploying changes.

GOLDEN RULE

Measure → Analyze → Change → Validate → Repeat

KEY TAKEAWAY Performance tuning is a continuous process — understand your app, measure accurately, change carefully, validate consistently.

COMMON MEMORY PROBLEMS IN JAVA

Memory issues can degrade performance, cause long GC pauses, or crash your application.



Detect Early

Monitor memory usage and GC activity.



Understand Root Cause

Find what is holding memory and why it's growing.



Fix the Cause

Change code or configuration to remove the issue.



Validate

Measure again to ensure the problem is resolved.



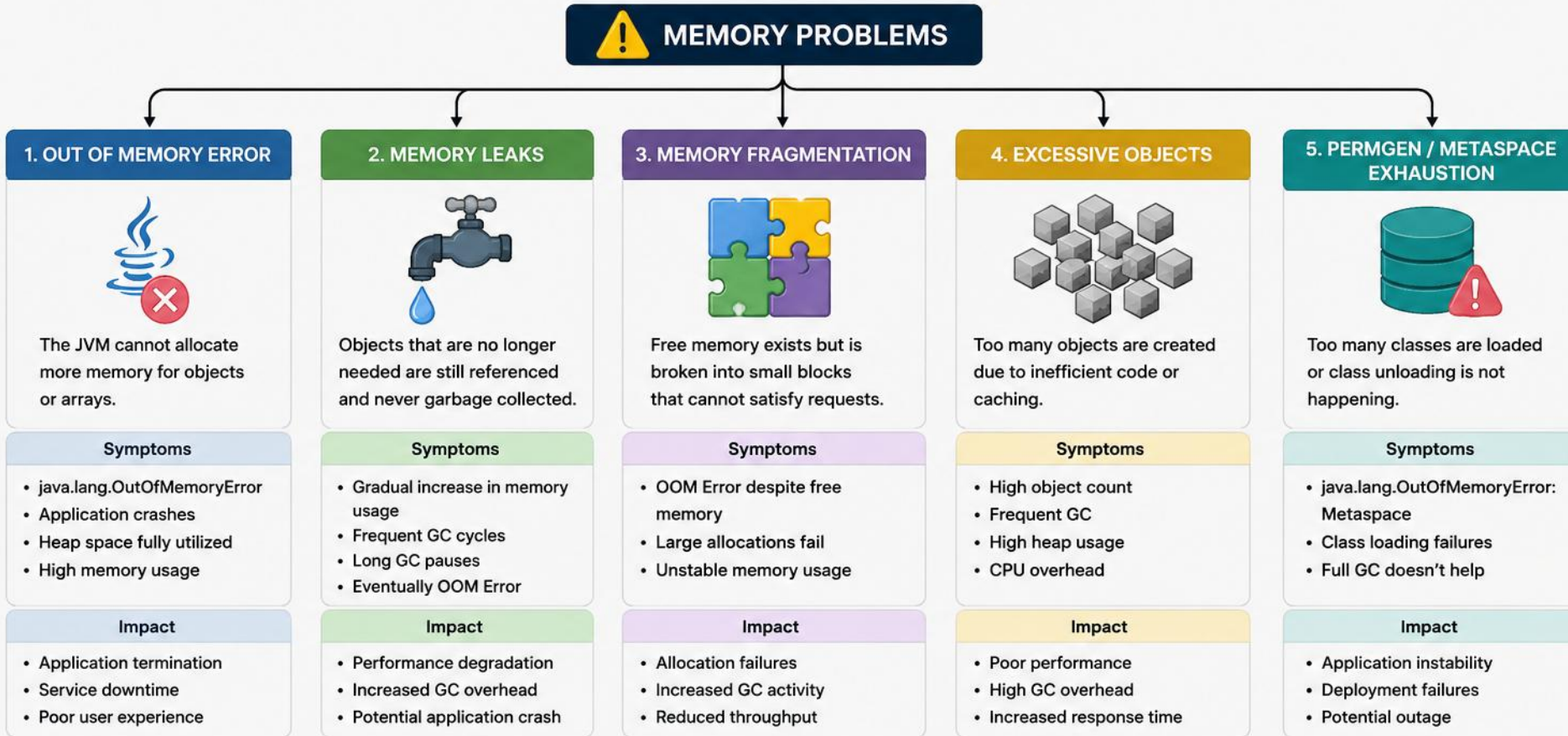
Prevent

Follow best practices to avoid recurring issues.

KEY TAKEAWAY JVM manages memory automatically, but your code decides what becomes unreachable.

MEMORY PROBLEMS IN JAVA

Common memory problems can degrade performance, cause application crashes, or lead to unstable behavior in production systems.



HOW TO DETECT AND DIAGNOSE

 **jstat**
Monitor GC and memory statistics

 **jmap**
Heap dump and memory usage

 **jvisualvm**
Visual monitoring and profiling

 **MAT (Eclipse)**
Analyze heap dumps and find leaks

 **GC Logs**
Analyze GC behavior and pauses

PROBLEM PATTERNS — PART 1

Memory Leak, Heap-Space OOM, and Metaspace OOM.

Memory Leak

Objects no longer needed are still referenced and can't be collected.

Fix: remove unnecessary references, deregister listeners, use cache eviction.

OOM — Heap Space

Heap is full and the JVM cannot allocate more memory.

```
List<Integer> list = new  
ArrayList<>();  
while (true) { list.add(1); }
```

Fix: reduce allocations, increase heap only if truly required.

OOM — Metaspace

JVM runs out of Metaspace, which stores class metadata.

Fix: avoid unnecessary dynamic class loading; raise -XX:MaxMetaspaceSize.

KEY TAKEAWAY Each of these problems has a distinct signature in GC logs and heap dumps once you know what to look for.

PROBLEM PATTERNS — PART 2

GC Thrashing, Large Object/Array Issues, and Unclosed Resources.

GC Thrashing

JVM spends too much time in GC trying to free memory.

Fix: increase heap, reduce object churn, tune GC settings.

Large Object / Array Issues

Very large objects consume a lot of contiguous memory.

```
byte[] data = new byte[500 *  
1024 * 1024];  
// 500 MB array
```

Fix: process large payloads in chunks instead of loading them all at once.

Unclosed Resources

Files, sockets, and DB connections not closed properly.

```
InputStream in = new  
FileInputStream("f");  
// not closed
```

Fix: process in chunks / use try-with-resources.

KEY TAKEAWAY Large-object and unclosed-resource issues are easy to reproduce in a load test — don't wait for production to find them.

USEFUL TOOLS & BEST PRACTICES

The toolkit and the habits that keep memory problems rare.



Eclipse MAT

Analyze heap dumps and find memory leaks.



VisualVM

Monitor memory, threads, GC, heap dumps.



JConsole

Built-in JVM monitoring tool.



JFR

Low-overhead profiling and event recording.



GC Logs

Understand GC behavior and tuning.

- Keep heap size appropriate (-Xms and -Xmx).
- Write memory-efficient code; avoid unnecessary object creation.
- Use collections and caches wisely; close resources and connections.
- Remove unused references; use weak/soft references where appropriate.

KEY TAKEAWAY Memory problems rarely have a single cause — measure, analyze, and fix the real root cause for lasting results.

BEST PRACTICES — CONTINUED

The remaining habits, plus what to always keep in mind.

- Monitor production systems continuously.
- Test under realistic load.
- Review and tune regularly.

TIP

Memory problems rarely have a single cause. Measure, analyze, and fix the real root cause for lasting results.

KEY TAKEAWAY Efficient code + proper configuration + monitoring = high performance and stable applications.

LAB OVERVIEW — MEMORY AND GARBAGE COLLECTION

The graded Lab 4: turn every diagram in this module into working Java code you run and observe yourself.

LAB OBJECTIVES

- Explain stack (per-thread frames) vs. heap (shared objects), and trace locals across nested calls.
- Allocate heap objects and use `identityHashCode()` to tell references apart from objects.
- Narrate the object lifecycle: create → use → share → drop references → GC-eligible.
- Allocate a large batch, null the reference, and observe used memory before and after GC.
- Monitor heap usage with `Runtime.getRuntime()` (total / free / used / max).
- Reproduce a reachable-collection memory leak, fix it, and compare strong vs. `WeakReference` behavior.
- Enable GC logging, tune `-Xms/-Xmx`, and measure allocation cost with `System.nanoTime()`.

KEY TAKEAWAY Lab 4 is built around one scenario — a banking batch job with a memory problem — solved through nine small Java programs.

LAB ENVIRONMENT & WORKFLOW

What you need, and the twelve-step loop you'll follow through Lab 4.

LAB ENVIRONMENT



JDK Version

Java 21 (required)



IDE

IntelliJ IDEA Community
(primary) / VS Code
(optional)



OS

Windows / macOS / Linux



Tools

jstat, jconsole, VisualVM (all
optional)

LAB WORKFLOW

1. Build — write demos

2. Trigger — GC & leaks

3. Measure — read logs

4. Reflect — fill & submit

KEY TAKEAWAY You will write and run nine Java programs against one banking-batch-job scenario, tuning heap size and GC logging as you go.

PRE-LAB EXERCISES OVERVIEW (1-4)

Four short warm-ups to complete before opening the full Lab 4 guide.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
1	Stack vs Heap Basics	Tiny program with locals plus one new object; note what lives on stack vs. heap.
2	Object Lifecycle	Create objects, null a reference, optionally call <code>System.gc()</code> ; describe reachability.
3	Garbage Collection in Action	Allocate in a loop with a small heap; capture evidence that GC activity occurred.
4	G1 Collector Flag	Run a short program with <code>-XX:+UseG1GC</code> and record the command used.

KEY TAKEAWAY These are quick warm-ups, not the graded lab — Lab 4 itself is covered on the next slides.

PRE-LAB EXERCISES (5-7) & LAB 4 PREVIEW

The last three warm-ups, then what the real, graded Lab 4 covers.

#	TITLE	FOCUS
5	ZGC Flag	Run a short program with -XX:+UseZGC and record the command used, comparing against Exercise 4's G1 run.
6	Leak Sketch (safe)	Grow a capped static List that retains references, then write a root-cause note.
7	String vs StringBuilder	Compare naive String concatenation vs. StringBuilder for ~50,000 iterations by timing both.
→	Lab 4: Memory Management & GC	The graded lab — banking batch job scenario, 9 Java demos, 100-mark rubric.
★	Business Scenario	A banking batch job keeps crashing with OutOfMemoryError — you investigate why.

KEY TAKEAWAY Finish these seven warm-ups first — Lab 4 assumes you're already comfortable with stack, heap, and GC basics.

USEFUL COMMANDS

The commands Lab 4 asks you to run and capture evidence from.

```
javac *.java                # Compile all Lab 4 demos
java -Xlog:gc GarbageCollectionDemo # Run with GC logging
jstat -gc <PID> 1000 5        # GC stats every second, 5 times
jmap -dump:live,format=b,file=heap.hprof <PID> # Optional heap dump (delete after use)
-Xms128m -Xmx512m PerformanceTest    # Heap sizing for the performance test
```

- Compile once with `javac *.java`, then run each demo on its own.
- Save GC log and memory-report snippets under `notes/` as you go.
- Never commit `.hprof` heap dumps — delete them after a quick look.

KEY TAKEAWAY These are the exact commands Steps 6, 7, 10, and 11 of the Lab 4 guide ask you to run.

LAB 4 TASKS AND DELIVERABLES

What the real Lab 4 asks you to build and submit.

LAB 4 DELIVERABLES

- Nine working demo classes, from Person to PerformanceTest.
- Memory/GC screenshots and a short -Xlog:gc snippet.
- A completed performance table across five object counts.
- notes/lab4-answers.md with reflection answers.
- No .hprof heap dumps, secrets, or verbatim solution copies.

KEY TAKEAWAY A grader should be able to re-run your notes and understand your results without ever opening a heap dump.

LAB 4 — STEPS 1–3: SETUP, STACK & HEAP

Building the workspace, then the stack and heap demos.

1 Workspace & Shared Types

- Create the examples/Lab4-MemoryManagement workspace.
- Add Person.java and MemoryMonitor.java (heap reports + GC hint).
- Confirm JDK 21 with `java -version` and `javac -version`.

File: Person.java,
MemoryMonitor.java

2 StackExample — Nested Frames

- Declare locals in main; call methodA → methodB → methodC.
- Print primitive values, references, and identityHashCode per frame.
- Confirm each frame disappears when its method returns.

File: StackExample.java

3 HeapExample — Objects on the Heap

- Print a memory report before allocation.
- Create several small objects (Student, Employee, Customer, Book).
- Print a memory report after allocation and compare.

File: HeapExample.java

KEY TAKEAWAY These first three steps build the workspace and prove references (stack) are not the same as objects (heap).

LAB 4 — STEPS 4–6: LIFECYCLE, GC & LEAKS

From reachability to garbage collection to a real memory leak.

4

ObjectLifecycle — Create → Null → Eligible

- Create a Person and alias it with a second reference.
- Set both references to null.
- Trigger GC and print before/after memory reports.

File: ObjectLifecycle.java

5

GarbageCollectionDemo + GC Logging

- Allocate ~100,000 objects, then null the array reference.
- Trigger GC and print an After GC memory report.
- Re-run with -Xlog:gc and save a short log snippet.

File: GarbageCollectionDemo.java

6

MemoryLeakDemo — leak vs. fix

- leak mode: add to a static list that is never cleared.
- fix mode: use a local list, clear it, null it, then trigger GC.
- Compare rising vs. recovered used-memory readings.

File: MemoryLeakDemo.java

KEY TAKEAWAY The leak/fix comparison is worth 20 of the 100 rubric marks — the single largest line item.

LAB 4 — STEPS 7–8: WEAK REFERENCES & PERFORMANCE

Comparing strong and weak retention, then measuring allocation cost.

7 WeakReferenceDemo

- Hold a strong Person reference and confirm it survives GC.
- Wrap another Person in a WeakReference.
- Null the strong local, trigger GC, and check weakReference.get().
- Document that System.gc() is a hint, not a guarantee.

File: WeakReferenceDemo.java

8 PerformanceTest, Tools & Reflection

- Time allocations from 10 to 1,000,000 objects and fill the results table.
- Optionally attach jstat, jconsole, or VisualVM to a running demo.
- Answer the reflection questions in notes/lab4-answers.md.

File: PerformanceTest.java

KEY TAKEAWAY Step 11 is optional tooling — Step 12's reflection notes are required and carry real rubric marks.

LAB 4 DELIVERABLES & CHECKPOINTS

What Lab 4 asks you to submit, checkpoint by checkpoint.



Lab 4 Deliverables

- Nine working demo classes, from Person to PerformanceTest.
- Memory/GC screenshots, a -Xlog:gc snippet, and the performance table.
- notes/lab4-answers.md with reflection answers.
- No .hprof heap dumps, secrets, or verbatim solution copies.



Implementation Checkpoints

- Checkpoint A: workspace, Person, and MemoryMonitor compile.
- Checkpoint B: Stack, Heap, and Lifecycle demos run correctly.
- Checkpoint C: GC, leak, weak-reference, and performance demos complete.
- Checkpoint D: no .hprof in Git; screenshots show no secrets.
- Mark each checkpoint Pass or Fail in your lab notes.

KEY TAKEAWAY Graders score the reachability narrative and the leak/fix comparison as heavily as whether the code compiles.

LAB 4 EVALUATION RUBRIC (100 MARKS)

How the real, graded Lab 4 is scored, and the ground rules for submission.

EVALUATION CRITERIA	WEIGHT
Stack vs. Heap Demonstration	15%
Object Lifecycle & GC Demo	25%
JVM Memory Monitoring	15%
Memory Leak Creation & Resolution	20%
Performance, Analysis & Code Quality	25%

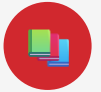
- Never commit .hprof heap dumps — they may contain sensitive data.
- Delete class files and dumps during cleanup; keep .java sources and notes.

KEY TAKEAWAY The leak/fix comparison and memory monitoring carry the most marks combined — measure, don't guess.

MODULE 4 SUMMARY

Java manages memory automatically through the JVM, but understanding how it works helps you build reliable, efficient, scalable applications.

1. MEMORY FUNDAMENTALS



Stack

- Per-thread memory.
- Primitives, references, method frames.
- Fixed size and very fast.
- Automatically managed — no GC involvement.



Heap

- Shared by all threads.
- Stores all objects and arrays.
- Dynamically allocated, GC-managed.
- Objects live here even when referenced from the stack.

KEY TAKEAWAY Key idea: objects are created on the heap and referenced from the stack.

2. OBJECT LIFECYCLE & GARBAGE COLLECTION

The lifecycle recap, and why GC matters.



- New: Object is created. In Use: reachable by at least one reference.
- Unreachable: no references point to the object.
- GC Benefits: prevents memory leaks (when code is correct), improves developer productivity, enhances application stability.

KEY TAKEAWAY Garbage Collection reclaims memory automatically — your code determines what is reachable.

3. GC ALGORITHMS & 4. COMMON MEMORY PROBLEMS

Choosing the right collector, and the failure modes to watch for.



G1 (Balanced)

- Designed for server apps.
- Predictable GC pauses.



ZGC (Low Latency)

- Designed for TB-scale heaps.
- Sub-millisecond pauses.



Memory Leaks

Referenced objects that can't be collected.



OOM – Heap

Heap full; JVM cannot allocate.



OOM – Metaspace

Too many classes loaded.



GC Thrashing

Too much time spent in GC.



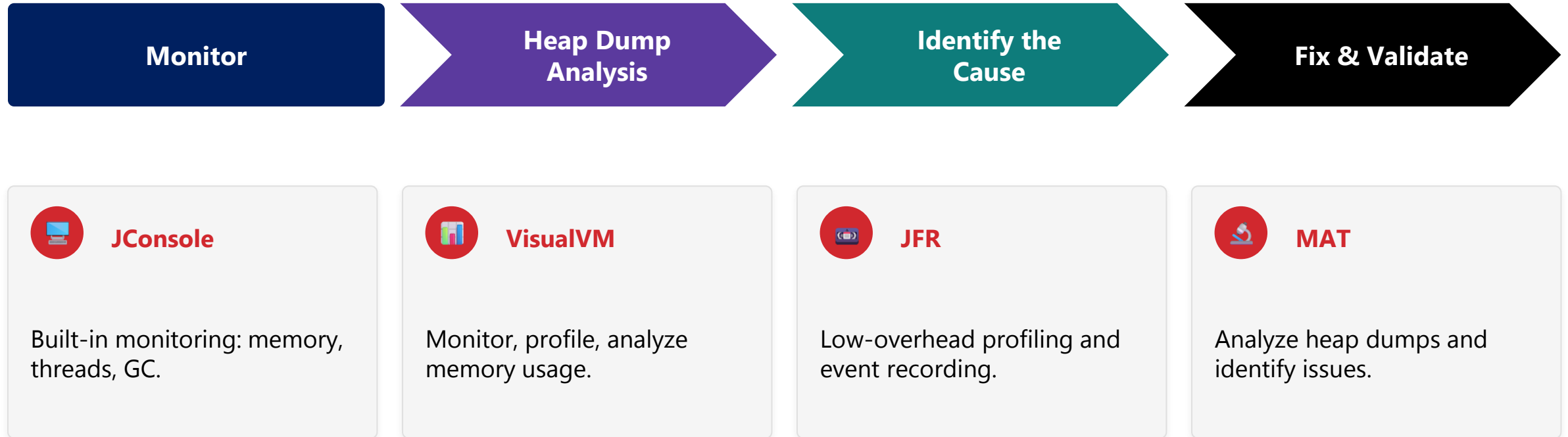
Unclosed Resources

Files/connections/streams leaks.

KEY TAKEAWAY Choose the right GC based on your needs: G1 for balanced performance, ZGC for low latency at scale.

5. DIAGNOSING MEMORY ISSUES & 7. USEFUL TOOLS

The diagnostic loop, and the tools that support it.



KEY TAKEAWAY Examine dominator trees, histograms, and GC logs to identify the cause — then fix and validate.

PERFORMANCE TUNING RECAP & KEY TAKEAWAYS

The tuning habits that matter, and the six ideas this module builds toward.

6. PERFORMANCE TUNING BASICS

- Right-Size the Heap: set -Xms and -Xmx appropriately.
- Reduce Allocations: reuse objects, use object pools.
- Use Efficient Data Structures: avoid boxing.
- Minimize Synchronization: use concurrent collections.
- I/O and Resources: buffered I/O, close resources promptly.
- Measure & Iterate: validate and repeat.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Understand how stack and heap work, and how objects live and die.
- GC reclaims memory automatically — your code determines what is reachable.
- Choose the appropriate GC and tune heap settings for your workload.
- Know common memory problems and detect them early.
- Use the right tools to measure, diagnose, and improve performance.
- Optimize iteratively — focus on real bottlenecks, not assumptions.

KEY TAKEAWAY Goal: write Java applications that use memory efficiently, perform well, and scale reliably in production.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK — MULTIPLE CHOICE (1–5)

Choose the best answer. Correct answers are marked ✓.

1. Which memory area in Java is used for local variables and method calls?

- A) Heap **B) Stack ✓** C) Metaspace D) Code Cache

2. Which area stores all objects and arrays in Java?

- A) Stack **B) Heap ✓** C) PC Register D) Native Method Stack

3. Which of the following is TRUE about object reachability?

- A) Objects on the stack are never reachable. B) Only objects in the heap can be reachable. **C) Unreachable objects are candidates for GC. ✓** D) Null references are always reachable.

4. Which GC algorithm is the default in most modern JDK versions (11+)?

- A) Serial GC B) Parallel GC **C) G1 GC ✓** D) ZGC

5. Which GC is designed for very low pause times for huge heaps (TBs)?

- A) G1 GC **B) ZGC ✓** C) JGC D) Shenandoah

KEY TAKEAWAY Five more multiple-choice questions continue on the next slide.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK — MULTIPLE CHOICE (6–10)

Choose the best answer. Correct answers are marked ✓.

6. What is a common cause of OutOfMemoryError: Java heap space?

- A) Too many threads **B) Heap is full and JVM cannot allocate more memory ✓** C) Stack overflow D) Too many open files

7. Which of the following is an example of a memory leak?

- A) Object becomes unreachable after method returns **B) Static collection holding references to objects ✓** C) Short-lived objects created in a loop D) Objects collected during GC

8. What command can you use to capture a heap dump?

- A) jcmd <pid> GC.heap_dump <file.hprof> ✓** B) jcmd <pid> GC.run C) jmap -dump <pid> D) jstat -gc <pid> 1000

9. Which tool is used to analyze heap dumps and find memory leaks?

- A) JConsole B) VisualVM C) Eclipse MAT **D) All of the above ✓**

10. Which of the following helps reduce GC frequency?

- A) Increase object churn **B) Use object pooling where appropriate ✓** C) Create unnecessary temporary objects D) Use large, short-lived collections

KEY TAKEAWAY 20 marks total across this knowledge check — 10 for multiple choice.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK — TRUE OR FALSE

Five statements, one point each.

STATEMENT	ANSWER
Stack memory is shared among all threads.	False
The Garbage Collector reclaims memory of unreachable objects.	True
ZGC is not suitable for large heaps.	False
OOM: Metaspace occurs when class metadata grows beyond the Metaspace limit.	True
Tools like VisualVM can show CPU usage but not memory.	False

KEY TAKEAWAY Stack memory is per-thread, not shared — that distinction trips up a lot of learners.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK — SHORT ANSWER (1–2)

Two points each.

1 Stack vs. Heap — Two Key Differences

- Stack stores local variables and method call frames; Heap stores objects and arrays.
- Stack is automatically managed and thread-specific; Heap is shared among threads and managed by the GC.

2 Two Ways Memory Leaks Occur

- Static collections retaining object references.
- Resources (files, sockets, DB connections) not closed properly.
- (Other valid answers: listeners/callbacks not deregistered, caches without eviction.)

KEY TAKEAWAY Both leak causes come down to the same root idea: something still holds a reference.

SHORT ANSWER (3) & SCENARIO (1)

G1's benefits, and choosing a GC under real symptoms.



Two Benefits of G1 GC

- Predictable pause times.
- Good balance between throughput and latency for large heap applications.



Scenario: 8GB Heap, Long GC Pauses, Short-Lived Objects

- a) G1 GC — optimized for large heaps, handles short-lived objects via generational collection, predictable pauses.
- b) Adjust heap sizing (-Xms/-Xmx); set -XX:MaxGCPauseMillis= <ms>.

KEY TAKEAWAY When symptoms point to long pauses on a large heap of short-lived objects, G1 is almost always the right default.

SCENARIO BASED (2)

OutOfMemoryError: Java heap space in production — what do you do?

List three steps to diagnose and fix the issue:

- i. Capture and analyze a heap dump using VisualVM or Eclipse MAT.
- ii. Review GC logs and monitor heap usage to identify leaks or excessive allocations.
- iii. Fix the root cause (remove memory leaks, reduce object creation, optimize data structures) and increase heap size if necessary.

KEY TAKEAWAY Diagnose before you scale — increasing heap size without fixing the root cause just delays the crash.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK — MATCH THE FOLLOWING

One point each. Answers are shown alongside each term.

TERM	ANSWER	DESCRIPTION
1. Heap Dump	E	Snapshot of heap memory for analysis
2. GC Throughput	C	Measure of how much time is spent doing useful work
3. Metaspace	A	Memory area that stores class metadata
4. Stop-The-World	D	Pauses all application threads during GC
5. Object Pooling	B	Technique to reuse objects to reduce allocations

KEY TAKEAWAY That's the full 20-mark Module 4 knowledge check — nicely done.

Nicely done

You can reason about memory, choose the right GC, and diagnose performance problems like a pro.

The Java Collections Framework is next in your toolkit.